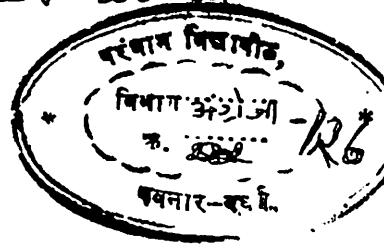


For Vinoba - a gift,

6/21/74

Your comments are quite welcome & would be much appreciated.

I, also, am seeking Truth.



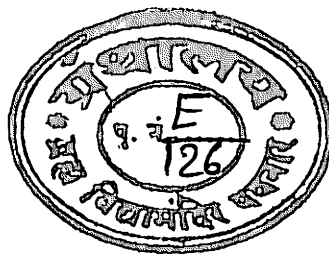
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VINOBA BHAVE
ON
SWARAJ (SELF-RULE) AND
REPRESENTATIVE DEMOCRACY

by
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Second Year Research Paper
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I dedicate this effort to one
who shows to me the joy of
a true friendship.



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INTRODUCTION

Although he is well-known throughout his native India, Vinoba Bhave, as an activist as well as a thinker, remains little known in the "West." As a kind of introduction to this introduction, therefore, I provide a brief picture of Vinoba, the man, and of the movements which have made him a saint to many of his countrymen. The unfamiliar reader thus introduced, I can feel more free to explain the project which is this paper.

The Man

On May 11, 1953, the cover of Time magazine was devoted to "a trusted and faithful disciple of the late Mahatma Gandhi."¹ In other articles throughout the 1950's Archarya Vinoba Bhave was variously described as a "mystic,"² "a practical saint,"³ and as "a skinny, penniless oldster with sunken cheeks, a wispy white mustache and beard."⁴ It was reported how "millions speak of him as the new

¹"A Man on Foot," Time 61: May 11, 1953, p. 32.

²Robert Trumbull, "'Holy Man' Who Walks in Gandhi's Steps," New York Times Magazine, February 10, 1952, p. 13.

³George Weller, "Vinoba Bhave: India's Walking Messiah," Yale Review 42: December, 1952, p. 238.

⁴"Bhoodan & Gramdan," Time 72: December 29, 1958, pp. 20-21.

Gandhi"⁵ and how many of India's leaders looked upon him as "Gandhi's moral heir."⁶

To be discussed in such terms is understandable given the background of Vinoba's life. Born into a Chitapavan Brahmin family on September 11, 1895, he was reared in a religious atmosphere to which the asceticism of his mother contributed greatly.⁷ At the age of twelve Vinoba had taken a vow of life-long chastity⁸ and by the age of twenty-one resolved to abandon his university studies in order to seek self-realization (moksha) in the holy city of Benaras.⁹ It was in that city that Vinoba's path crossed that of Mohandas K. Gandhi.

From 1916 to Gandhi's death in 1948, Vinoba deserves to be called "the son of Gandhi"¹⁰ for such was the relationship that existed between the two men. Vinoba so revered his adopted father that he once wrote to him in a letter that "with me, nothing counts in this world except your blessings."¹¹ From Gandhi's viewpoint Vinoba was

⁵A. M. Rosenthal, "The Story of a Saint," Coronet 39: January, 1956, p. 40.

⁶Weller, Yale Review, p. 244.

⁷Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1962), p. 11.

⁸Rosenthal, Coronet, p. 40.

⁹Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 13.

¹⁰"The Fifth Son," Time 58: November 26, 1951, p. 40.

¹¹"Letter to Bapu," cited by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 23.

was "a Bhim-a Hercules"¹² and even his spiritual superior in many ways.¹³ In 1940 Gandhi selected Vinoba even above Jawaharalal Nehru for the honor of initiating the individual resistance campaign against British rule in India. All totaled, Vinoba spent five years in prison during the independence movement.¹⁴

It was only after "independence" and Gandhi's assassination that Vinoba really proceeded into the world limelight. Holding that "the land problem . . . is the main problem for the whole of Asia"¹⁵ he began to propagate the saying of Tulsidas¹⁶ that "Sampati sab Raghupati Ki ahi" (all wealth, including land, belongs to God).¹⁷ Interpreting God, in this case, to mean "society"¹⁸ Vinoba called upon the rich and poor alike to voluntarily give up land for redistribution to the most desparate in their village.

Believing that "there is no human problem but can be solved

¹²Gandhi, quoted by Arthur Koestler, "Last of the Saints," Commentary 29: February, 1960, p. 147.

¹³See Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, pp. 23-23.

¹⁴Rosenthal, Coronet, p. 41.

¹⁵Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 38.

¹⁶Tulsidas is the revered translator of the epic poem Ramayana into the vernacular. He has the God-incarnation, Ram, expouse the quoted position.

¹⁷Tulsidas, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 418.

¹⁸Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 62.

by human intelligence"¹⁹ Vinoba appealed to both the heads and the hearts of the landed. To their heads he argued that his Bhoodan (Land-Gift) movement was the only alternative to the redistribution through violence advocated by the communists.²⁰ He told them, in other words, that it was in their self-interest to part with a portion of their land since "the time will come when he who has great possessions will be looked on as a thief."²¹

To self-interest he added an appeal to the heart which said: "it is more blessed to give than to receive."²² The spiritual attainment of the society would be enhanced, he maintained, as individuals came to realize that "God dwells in the hearts of all beings"²³ and demands service particularly with regards to the poorest. Speaking of the landed, therefore, Vinoba observed how they "should remember that I am not asking for alms but want land as a matter of right"²⁴ and how he was "initiating them into the tenets of a new ideal."²⁵

¹⁹Vinoba Bhаве, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 66.

²⁰In Telingana District, Hyderabad, where the movement began, some 3,000 persons had been killed by communists and rebellious poor. See "Communism v. Gandhi's 'Son,'" Time 57: June 4, 1951, p. 36.

²¹Vinoba Bhаве, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 190.

²²"A Man on Foot," Time, p. 32.

²³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 8.

²⁴Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 71.

²⁵Ibid.

The "new ideal" was represented in a word of ancient usage which had been resurrected by Gandhi: Sarvodaya. This is a Sanskrit word comprised of Sarva (all) and Udaya (rising) which may be roughly translated as meaning "the all-round well being or good of all."²⁶ While important implications of the ideal will occupy much of the body of this paper, it may be here observed that faith in such a "common good" inspired Vinoba to journey, on foot, at least 25,000 miles, village to village, between 1951 and 1960.²⁷ The appeals of Vinoba and his few coworkers, moreover, drew contributions of some eight million acres of land from over 700,000 donors during this same period.²⁸

Before entering into his present retirement Vinoba saw a fantastic growth in a second movement initiated as a sequel to Bhoodan. Gramdan, also an offspring of the Sarvodaya ideal, strikes more deeply at the "ownership complex"²⁹ by demanding surrender, by the individual, of all one's land to the village community. Gramdan, or "village-gift," becomes the term applied to a village when at least seventy-five percent of the people owning at least fifty

²⁶Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 17.

²⁷Koestler, Commentary, p. 141. (One writer says 35,000 miles--Kingsley Martin, "The Gandhi Way," Atlantic Monthly 206: August, 1960), p. 63.)

²⁸Ibid., p. 143. (It should be noted that this is far short of Vinoba's goal of fifty million acres by this date.)

²⁹Vinoba Bhawe, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957), p. 3.

percent of the land sign a pledge relinquishing their private ownership.³⁰ Today there are over 100,000 Gramdan villages in India—over one-seventh of the total number of villages in the country.³¹

My Project

Given this background, it is not surprising that most analysts of Vinoba Bhave have focussed upon the relationship of the Bhoodan and Gramdan movements to the religious concepts underlying Sarvodaya as well as on the task of criticizing these movements from a pragmatic perspective.³² Curiously enough, however, almost all of these writers have failed to deal with Vinoba's conviction that "since India's accession to freedom our people have become slaves."³³ Indeed, few have even commented upon his assertion that:

The truth is that no real freedom exists today, and we shall not get it so long as we carry on with our 'representative democracy' and do not take the management of our own village affairs into our own hands.³⁴

³⁰Devi Prasad, "Gramdan: The Land Revolution in India," War Resistance 1969 Vols. 28-29, p. 30. (Note: this pledge was made easier in 1963 when, instead of having to relinquish use of one-sixth of one's land, one needed to part with only one-twentieth.)

³¹What Sarvodaya Stands For (Wardha: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1974), p. 66.

³²The following works are the best available (see the bibliography for details of publisher, etc.): The Social and Political Philosophy of Sarvodaya After Gandhi by Vishwanath Tandon, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study by Adi H. Doctor, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought by Indu Tikekar, A Great Society of Small Communities by Sugata Dasgupta, and The Gentle Anarchists by Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell.

³³Vinoba Bhave, Gramdan for Gramswaraj (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 37.

³⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 64-65. (underlines mine)

Those who have dealt, to some extent, with Vinoba's criticisms of majority rule, party rule, the nature of power and of the nature of representation itself usually include in their analyses some mention of swaraj. Vinoba tells us that

Swaraj is a term in Vedic language. It is defined thus: Swarajya is the government of each by each, i.e., it is such a government that it will seem to each to be his own rule, or government by all, or Ramrajya (Kingdom of God.)³⁵

Even with such clear reference to the religious importance of the term "swaraj", none that I have read have sought to explain Vinoba's criticisms in the light of his religious-conceptual framework. If "real freedom," for example, has an essentially spiritual connotation I fail to see how Vinoba's attack upon representative government can be understood, let alone be dealt with fairly, outside of his framework. My present conviction that "real freedom" has such a meaning and the fact that others have overlooked the importance of Vinoba's religious thought upon his political position affords me an opportunity to break some new ground.

It is, accordingly, the purpose of this paper to indicate the relationship of "swaraj" and "real freedom" to each other in the context of Vinoba's religious framework as well as to examine Vinoba's critique of representative democracy in the light of this framework. I intend to show how he comes to assert the implicit proposition that representative democracy stifles the development of man as a spiritual

³⁵Vinoba Bhawe, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 37.

being and then to evaluate the consistency with which his prescriptions for action or inaction reflect this view.

This enterprise bears the burden of several major problems. First among these is the generally unsystematic nature of almost all of Vinoba's writings. Unlike James Madison in The Federalist, No. 10, Vinoba does not present his thoughts in a manner which some enterprising Robert Dahl would find clear to analyze.³⁶ To try to systemize Vinoba, nevertheless, is to some extent imperative for the sake of my analysis. A tension, therefore, is built up within me as I am conscious that, oftentimes, I may be falling into the role of an apologist or a manipulative critic rather than playing the scholarly part of an analyst who seeks to be as "objective" as possible.

A second major difficulty consists of the extreme complexity of Vinoba's thought, once one opens the floodgates into his religious framework. As it appears to me to be much more like an immense spider-web than not, I have frequently found myself at a loss to decide what to include in this paper.³⁷ Moreover, to say what is "essential" and what is merely a deduction is, in the context of a spider web, bound to result in unfair and unjustifiable oversimplification.

This leads into the last major problem which is integrally related to the concept of logic itself. Obviously the system of logic,

³⁶I refer to Robert A. Dahl, A Preface to Democratic Theory (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1970), pp. 4-33.

³⁷For example, I wondered whether or not to include a discussion of the "gunas," or "natural qualities" of man. Deciding to include such a discussion required a modification in the place of swadharma (duty) in the paper since its mention must precede the rajas guna yet cannot be well understood until after Karma yoga is discussed.

including the bias of culture, which is brought to bear upon any subject profoundly affects the analysis of that subject. When Vinoba, for example, informs us that "the very idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong"³⁸ it would be easy to immediately react against him as somehow illogical. It is difficult to relate to someone who, we must remember, is proceeding forth with a different value system, a different conception of polity, and even a conception of reality which departs from those most of us normally hold. Vi-

Indeed, some of his formulations are illogical if we confine ourselves to a somewhat static conception of what logic is. In Vinoba's conception of God, for example, God both is and is becoming to the extent that He is both existent beyond man and man is becoming merged with Him within man! In the former case there is no free will because God acts on man while in the latter case there is free will because the mind of man can either turn away from or towards the God within. While this paragraph, itself, may be incomprehensible outside of Vinoba's framework, it is sufficient for the reader to realize that sometimes Vinoba uses a dialectical form of logic which allows for a thing to both be and not be at the same time while at other times he employs a more formal logic which concludes that the ruling of one over oneself is incompatible with the ruling of others over oneself.

My approach in dealing with these problems includes:

(1) remaining as conscious of them as I am able to, (2) allowing Vinoba to speak for himself as often as, through my organization of his

³⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 2.
www.vinoba.in

thought, he is able to do so and (3) confining myself largely to the areas in which he utilizes formal logic or, at least, to not utilize formal logic to criticize areas of his thinking which clearly were never meant to conform to such criteria.

Accordingly, due to points two and three above, some of my analysis may appear to be either essentially descriptive or largely arbitrary. Such may or may not be the case. From my perspective, my integrity here rests largely upon allowing Vinoba to analyze himself (when possible) and in confining the scope of my analysis so as to deal adequately with that portion of his thought having an important bearing upon his religious critique of representative democracy.

Following this introduction the reader will find my analysis divided into three sections: "On Swaraj," "On Democracy," and "Conclusions." In the first section I discuss Vinoba's Sarvodaya conceptual (religious) framework while seeking to clarify the role that swaraj plays within that framework. The philosophy of Sarvodaya, as Vinoba has conceived it, "finds its justification in religion, makes its appeals in terms of Hindu moral precepts, is publicized through mythological allusions"³⁹ and may well try one's patience as its roots and implications are explored. I only ask the reader to plow through any apparently irrelevant material in the faith that its relevance will be later clear.

In the second section the information gained from preceding analyses sheds light upon Vinoba's opposition to external coercive rule

³⁹Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches, p. 43.

of any kind and, particularly, his dislike of rule by representatives is discussed. Emphasis is placed upon his concern for developing "nitī" (moral rule) as opposed to "raj" (rule of the State). With his implicit proposition established⁴⁰ I then evaluate some of his prescriptions for action or inaction within its context.

The last section is meant to both draw the loose strands of the paper together as well as to capsulize my impression of Vinoba's contribution. Avoiding more than a basic summary of the paper, I shall hope that the reader may consider a good, comprehensive summary to be the whole of the paper itself. Preceding the bibliography, however, I include an alphabetical reference to the meanings of all Indian terms used in this paper as well as a second appendix including my summarized impressions of what Vinoba means by God, Man, Society, State, and Government.

If any justification for the enterprise is considered necessary at this point, I can only admit that both Vinoba's conceptual framework and many of the prescriptions which follow from it make a lot of sense to me. My present bias agrees with Indu Tikekar's conviction that "basically, all human problems are spiritual and they should be treated integrally."⁴¹ The commitment that I share with Vinoba of seeking to find ways of resolving human conflict through non-violence, has also, undoubtedly, affected my decision to study him.

⁴⁰The proposition, again, being that: Representative democracy stifles the development of man as a spiritual being.

⁴¹Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. xviii.

Consider this to be an intellectual exercise involving a self-introspection, if nothing more. Although reason may not be capable of establishing faith, still it may be employed to either support it or to bring one to the point of changing it. In this sense, perhaps Vinoba's following statement might be rendered intelligible:

When blind faith is shaken, there is no harm in it But blind unbelief should not replace blind belief. It is not as if belief alone can be blind, that it has a monopoly of blindness. Unbelief too can be blind.⁴²

To the extent to which we are able to see life in general and politics in particular through the eyes of one from another culture, perhaps our own perspectives may be that much more broadened.

⁴²Vinoba Bhave, Talks on the Gita (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 228.

I. ON SWARAJ

In the beginning of the book, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, Vinoba Bhave informs us that

Sarvodaya means that the good of all resides in the good of one. That there could be interests of one person, which are against the interests of another is inconceivable. Similarly, there could be no interests of one community, class or country which would be against the interests of any other community, class or country. The idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong.¹

Such an assertion, which for Vinoba has the logical status of a presupposition,² probably seems absurd to most of us who have been reared and geared to proceed from the opposite assumption. It must, however, be admitted that "any notion of 'the natural disharmony of interests' is, despite appearances, no more empirical than its opposite."³ If it may be agreed that the existence or non-existence of a particular God is beyond empirical proof⁴ then a conception of a

¹Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 2. (my underlines)

²Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), p. 44 footnote.

³Ibid.

⁴See Arnold Brecht, Political Theory: The Foundations of Twentieth Century Political Thought (Princeton, Princeton University Press, 1970), p. 87 etc.

common "good of all"⁵ which is predicated upon a conception of God would also be beyond the capacity of the scientific method to verify or disprove.

To even begin to understand the thought of Vinoba Bhave, therefore, it is necessary to realize that it "represents the Indian Idealistic tradition of the Vedanta."⁶ Admitting having studied the works of Shankaracharya, a formulator of this tradition, "more than of anyone else,"⁷ Vinoba agrees with that teacher in holding that "therein dwells in every man the same spirit."⁸ This "spirit," also called the soul or self, "is to be sought in our own hearts"⁹ but is, according to Shankara, that same universal soul or Atman which informs all that is. It is in this context that Vinoba observes how "the beautiful atman within me is within the insect too."¹⁰

Vinoba's ideal of samya yoga, or reverence for all life, accordingly "makes no distinction between man and man" and even sees

⁵"... the good of all is contained in the good of each," Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 17.

⁶Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 124.

⁷Vinoba Bhave, Language Problem (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965), p. 8.

⁸Vinoba Bhave quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1962), p. 471. (my underline)

⁹Ibid., p. 169.

¹⁰Vinoba Bhave, Talks on the Gita (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 137.
www.vinoba.in

"no ultimate difference in the spirit of man and other animals."¹¹ Not only do "all men belong to one human family"¹² by virtue of the One God being in each person, but also man is viewed as but one manifestation of "that God (who) is present in all the forms of creation."¹³

Man, however, is unique in that his mind alone has the capacity to reflect upon his being. As will be discussed later, it is a crucial prerogative of the mind to will attitudes which may either impede spiritual progress or overcome the illusion of separation which allows for final self-realization (moksha) to occur. It is to this end which Vinoba refers when he says that: "the ultimate human good is not subjective, differing from individual to individual, it is uniform in nature."¹⁴ The idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong, therefore, because the only true interest is common to all persons.

Accordingly, for example, religious conflicts are illusory. He recognizes that "the growth of dogmas and rigid institutions around religions"¹⁵ has created much division, but holds, nevertheless, that "all religions believe in love, compassion, affection and peace, and in this respect they have a common belief."¹⁶ Thus, "all religions are

¹¹ Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 471.

¹² Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 250.

¹³ Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 131.

¹⁴ Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 150.

¹⁵ Vinoba Bhave, Christ The Love Incarnate (Vananasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1964), p. 39.

¹⁶ Ibid., pp. 46-47.

partial embodiments of Truth"¹⁷ or, to put it differently "Hinduism, Islam and other religions are different formulations of only one basic religion, namely, Truth."¹⁸ From Vinoba's viewpoint, therefore, the ethical content of a religion is its essence while "the highest goal of spiritual life lies in the ultimate experience . . . in which the worshipper . . . is merged and becomes one with the Infinite."¹⁹ Because, Vinoba maintains, the essence of every religion is the same, Truth cannot oppose Truth and hence "there can never be opposition between two religions."²⁰

Similarly, Vinoba holds that "the worth of a society is judged by its individuals"²¹ who constitute its essence. Since the essence or soul of each individual is the same, Truth that is Atman cannot oppose Truth, and again all conflict is illusion caused by "a false notion of what constitutes our interest."²² Since, in addition, a society is no more than the individuals who compose it, the "basic oneness of all life removes the possibility of conflict between the good of the individual and that of society."²³ The concept of sarvodaya comes to include

¹⁷Vinoba Bhawe, Random Reflections (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1971), p. 15. (Truth = Ultimate Reality; Atman.)

¹⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 35.

¹⁹Swami Yatiswarananda, "A Glimpse Into Hindu Religious Symbolism," in The Cultural Heritage of India (Calcutta: Ramakrishna Mission, 1956), Vol. IV, p. 435.

²⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 55.

²¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231.

²²Vinoba Bhawe, Democratic Values, p. 18.

²³Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 256.

the belief that "the good of the individual is contained in the good of all,"²⁴ as well as the conviction that the good of all is contained in the good of each individual.²⁵

To those who do not believe in a "common good of all" but hold, rather, that the goal should be "the greatest good for the greatest number" Vinoba observes that "utilitarianism takes its utility for granted."²⁶ It fails to be useful, according to Vinoba, when it comes to the ultimate goal of realizing the Oneness of all life. In fact, as we shall see in section two, Vinoba goes even further by asserting that utilitarian instrumentalities—like a tradition of "majority rule"—may even serve to inhibit the growth of this realization.

To others, like Marx, who proceed upon the assumption of a conflict of self or class interests, Vinoba complains that such bases undermine "the very foundation of fellow feeling and mutual help."²⁷ Indeed, so monistic is Vinoba's perspective that even the concept of "the struggle for existence" is "unjustified"²⁸ as a denial of spiritual unity. However, while conflicts among individuals are born of ignorance of their common good, Vinoba does believe that capitalism and

²⁴Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 35.

²⁵To avoid possible confusion, "sarvodaya" as here used should be taken, as in this paper generally, to mean "the sarvodaya of Vinoba Bhawe," since, as Indu Tikekar points out in Integral Revolution, pp. 146-147, not all Sarvodaya thinkers are Vedantans.

²⁶Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 104.

²⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 9.

²⁸Ibid., p. 179.

competition, generally, impedes the realization of this truth.

Significantly, Vinoba maintains that "Capitalism cannot be ended by love or conflict, but by right thought."²⁹ However "right thought" in this context is quite far from Marx's conception of consciousness because it is not dependent, in any way, upon one's material environment. "Right thought" is dependent upon one's bhavana (mental attitude), which has "the power to transform all things."³⁰ Indeed, in this sense, "it is the eye of the beholder that determines the form of the world,"³¹ not visa versa. Capitalism, in this context, is caused, like all "sources" of conflict, by a wrong attitude or perspective as to what is real in the world.

The source of all wrong attitudes, however, is taught to one by one's environment. This source is the bhavana that "I am the body" which "builds a wall around me and cuts me off"³² from others. Vinoba observes that "from childhood we are taught to worship this deity, the body" and "we impress on the child's mind the idea that he is the body."³³ This, argues Vinoba, emphasizes the notion of "difference"³⁴ upon the individual and builds a life "on the foundation

²⁹Vinoba Bhawe, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 130.

³⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 108.

³¹Ibid., p. 109.

³²Ibid., p. 12.

³³Ibid., p. 162.

³⁴Ibid., p. 231.

of fear"³⁵ which is conducive to selfishness and conflict.

According to Vinoba "obsession with the flesh . . . is the source of all fear"³⁶ and "it is because of fear that tyranny becomes possible."³⁷ When people fall into "the whirlpool of beautifying the body"³⁸ and seek only to gratify their sensual desires and whims, naturally conflicts arise and the most physically strong and mentally clever will exploit others for their own ends. Those others, more often than not, will endure the exploitation because of the fear they hold with regards to asserting themselves.

The way to overcome this fear and, according to Vinoba, to progress to a realization of the Oneness of all life is to understand the truth of the Bhagavad Gita's thirteenth chapter: "Tat tvam asi" which means "'You are indeed the Self, ' you are not the body, you are the Self."³⁹ As interpreted by Vinoba this means that the Self or Atman in every person is "altogether distinct from the body, separate, entirely beautiful, bright, holy, and free of imperfection."⁴⁰ It is, in short "indestructable, flawless, transcending the body"⁴¹ and, hence, worthy to be exalted.

³⁵Ibid., p. 163.

³⁶Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 31.

³⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 167.

³⁸Ibid., p. 166.

³⁹Ibid.

⁴⁰Ibid., p. 163.

⁴¹Ibid., p. 167.

The revolutionary flavor of the perspective may become more apparent as we see that "no true safety is possible so long as there is attachment to the body and consequent fear."⁴² The possibility of "real freedom" in either a spiritual or political sense, moreover, presupposes a conquering of fear since:

. . . when you give up attachment to the body, you become an emperor, you achieve freedom. All power comes into your hands. No one can exercise authority over you. The very basis of tyranny breaks down⁴³

"True safety" and "real freedom," in this context, consists in wilfully surrendering to the Self who then "guides us all from within."⁴⁴ In a word, they consist in attaining to the ideal of moksha. Thus, while God has given us freedom to identify ourselves with the body, He has also given the mind the capacity to will a new bhavana by which attachment to the body may be transcended.⁴⁵ To be truly free and safe in either a spiritual or political sense, therefore, requires that we progressively realize that "common good" which is moksha and individually admit that "I am the Self." It is the extent to which this bhavana is mastered, according to Vinoba, that each individual "is then emperor of the world."⁴⁶

This, however, ought not to be taken to mean that the body

⁴²Ibid., p. 169.

⁴³Ibid., p. 168.

⁴⁴Ibid., p. 8.

⁴⁵Ibid.

⁴⁶Ibid., p. 169.

should be mortified in any way. While one must, according to Vinoba, see that "I am not this mortal body . . . I am the spirit that never dies,"⁴⁷ one must also realize that "the body has been given to me for the sake of the Self."⁴⁸ "The body is like one's clothes"⁴⁹ or a "machine"⁵⁰ which should be well used as an "instrument,"⁵¹ in the service of God's will. It needs to be treated well in other words, since it is a prerequisite for doing one's duty.⁵²

In Hindu tradition "everybody has a duty to fulfill."⁵³ In fact,

The very start of the teachings of the Gita is based on the principle that whatever might be the position in which a man is placed at birth, if he performs his duty with love, devotion, and singleness of purpose, he becomes worthy of moksha (self-realization).⁵⁴

This duty, or svadharma, consists of two parts according to Vinoba: the dharma, which changes, and the "natural duties" which never change.⁵⁵

To interpret dharma as changeable is highly revolutionary in

⁴⁷Ibid., p. 13.

⁴⁸Ibid., p. 167.

⁴⁹Ibid., p. 14.

⁵⁰Ibid., p. 165.

⁵¹Ibid., p. 16.

⁵²Generally, for most Hindus, including Vinoba, God's Will = to do one's duty.

⁵³Vinoba Bhawe, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957), p. 3.

⁵⁴Vinoba, Bhōdan Yajna, p. 39.

⁵⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 245.

the context of the traditional caste system. That system holds that "One's dharma consists in following one's true vocation"⁵⁶ which is, by nature, that which one is born into. Vinoba, however, holds that "the idea of associating birth in poverty or prosperity with previous life is totally absurd."⁵⁷ "True vocation," for him, is thrown open to change as he argues that "as the course of one's life changes through thinking and experience, one's old dharma drops off and a new dharma comes in its place."⁵⁸

There are, however, duties which are natural and unchanging, for example:

The service of the parents to whom I was born, the service of the neighbors amongst whom I find myself, these duties come to me naturally . . . my other obligations are matters of everyday experience. I feel hungry, I feel thirsty. So, to give food to the hungry and drink to the thirsty becomes my duty by nature.⁵⁹

While the doctrine of karma yoga, later to be discussed, will explain much of why such duties are "natural" there is, I believe, an additional rationale: a categorical imperative. Vinoba tells us that

The criterion which is employed in the science of ethics for determining whether from the point of view of morals a principle is right or wrong, and whether from a practical point of view it is advantageous or disadvantageous, is to extend it to apply to all men and

⁵⁶Ibid., p. 8.

⁵⁷Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 243.

⁵⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 7.

⁵⁹Ibid., p. 185.

see what the result is.⁶⁰

Since, as has been mentioned, the body "is given to us as a means, an instrument"⁶¹ to be used in God's service, and since the instrument needs to be well cared for to be of full service, to be denied basic bodily needs is an impediment to doing one's svadharma. Vinoba's admonition "to foster and cherish the body because only so can one perform one's svadharma"⁶² linked with an imperative to "do unto others as you would have them do unto you"⁶³ thus, at least, means that insofar as one has more than one needs for physical well-being, one's duty is to "give food to the hungry and drink to the thirsty."

Although "physical well-being" admittedly has different needs from individual to individual,⁶⁴ still "the body is to be paid its due hire—no more than that"⁶⁵ or one will tend to fall back into the spirit-denying "I am the body" bhavana. Clearly this would seem to be the basis from which Mēra Behn, another disciple of Gandhi, criticizes Vinoba's occasional acceptance of land gifts from the very poor: such gifts do not allow the giver's body its "due hire."⁶⁶

⁶⁰Vinoba Bhawe, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959), p. 83.

⁶¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 163.

⁶²Ibid., p. 16.

⁶³Vinoba, Christ, the Love-Incarnate, p. 22 (see also: The New Testament, Matthew 5-7).

⁶⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 43.

⁶⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 16. (underlines mine)

⁶⁶Mēra Behn, noted by Vera Michelas Dean in "India: A New Gandhi Walks the Dusty Roads," Reporter 9: Oct. 1953, p. 21.

Vinoba did fall into apparent contradiction, as he observed, during the Bhoodan Movement, that "the first step to bring about Sarvodaya . . . is antyodaya—the uplift of the last one."⁶⁷ Accordingly, he taught that "it is also the duty of the poor kisan⁶⁸ to give" because, from the point of view of the landless, he is somewhat better off.⁶⁹ This, he argued, would "give rise to a moral power that would affect the rich"⁷⁰—something which he saw actually happen on many occasions.⁷¹ Thus, argued Vinoba,

. . . everybody must make some sacrifice for the sake of those who are the most distressed in society even as all water of the globe flows towards the sea standing at the lowest level.⁷²

Clearly, however, as the sea level rises, the poorer people who once gave more than they could afford would be subsumed in the giving. Thus, while Vinoba might depart from the rationale of Mira Behn until a basic subsistence level is established for all, that rationale, might well be used by Vinoba to support his call for all to perform their svadharma. In the meantime even the poor would have an opportunity to discover that "man experiences joy and fulfillment in

⁶⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 181.

⁶⁸Kisan: one who works with his hands, in this case one who already needs all the land he has.

⁶⁹Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 2.

⁷⁰Ibid., p. 4.

⁷¹See Suresh Ram's numerous accounts in Vinoba and His Mission.

⁷²Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 2.

the measure which he gives."⁷³

At any rate, Vinoba maintains, "as man is a social being he is never happy when he partakes of a good thing by himself."⁷⁴ Proceeding from his metaphysical premise that "in reality it is impossible to separate the individual and society"⁷⁵ Vinoba views the prevailing values in a society as having a basis in the consensus of the people in that society. By mobilizing even the poor to adopt a new value orientation the status conferred upon the rich by the old order is undermined. "Moral pressure" is thus exerted with the aim of giving "the opportunity to the rich to give vent to their generous nature."⁷⁶

This is not to say, however, that man is simply "good" by nature. For Vinoba "none but God is wholly free from blemish . . . none too is an embodiment of absolute evil."⁷⁷ Of course, that God who "dwells in the hearts of all beings"⁷⁸ is, by definition, good. Still, while "the natural movement of one's soul is upwards" it is believed that "the burden of the body drags down the soul."⁷⁹ Man,

⁷³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 209.

⁷⁴Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 53.

⁷⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231. (It may be noteworthy to observe that at times Vinoba uses an organic analogy: "Just as between the different limbs and the organs of the body there is no conflict, but only harmony and cooperation, so too between individuals in society," Ibid., p. 232.)

⁷⁶Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 21.

⁷⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 2.

⁷⁸Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 8.

⁷⁹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 176.

accordingly, has the potential for evil as well as goodness insofar as the mind dwells upon the selfish comforts of the body. Indeed

There are many external forms assumed by the illusion that strews with thorns the path of svadharma. Yet, if we examine them, only one thing is at the bottom of it all, namely, a restricted and shallow identification of oneself with the body.⁸⁰

In Vinoba's framework "change always goes on in man"⁸¹ because the attractions of the body and the desire of the soul to realize itself are in constant conflict. It is in this context that he observes how "the Gita uses the allegory of war" and maintains that "to speak the truth, the real battle is only within ourselves."⁸² Full self-realization (Moksha), accordingly, becomes an ideal to be approached as one progressively abandons the bhavana of "I am the body." Hence, Vinoba admits:

I would say that ours is to secure control over all our senses, mind and heart. We refuse to be slave of them. Whence our Vedic Rishis⁸³ gave us the mantra 'Yatemahe Swarajya' (we shall strive to attain this Swaraj).⁸⁴

Individual swaraj (self-rule) becomes, in this context, a prerequisite to moksha! Rule of the Self over the body is attained as the mind is able to separate the two⁸⁵ in one's consciousness. To be able

⁸⁰Ibid., p. 12.

⁸¹Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 131.

⁸²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 208.

⁸³Rishi = Holy man, Sannyasin.

⁸⁴Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 128.

⁸⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 177.

to do this, Vinoba agrees with the orthodox Hindus, one must successfully overcome the "three gunas."⁸⁶ These "qualities of nature" are assumed present in all forms of life⁸⁷ and are, for Vinoba, represented in man primarily by laziness (tamas),⁸⁸ personal ambition (rajas)⁸⁹, and knowledge (sattva).⁹⁰ They may also be conceived of as being represented in one's instincts, emotions, and intellect, respectively.⁹¹

To overcome any instinctual laziness is, for Vinoba, essential for the maintenance of a healthy body which, as has been shown, is a prerequisite for doing one's svadharma. According to him, "experience shows that just as the mind is influenced by bodily sickness, so also good health has a bearing on mind."⁹² The more lazy one is, or the more one's bodily needs are not met, therefore, the more one tends to think "I am the body."

Tamas is, accordingly, overcome by the performance of bodily labor.⁹³ This cure, moreover, has social significance insofar

⁸⁶Ibid.

⁸⁷See Alain Danielou, Hindu Polytheism (New York: Pantheon Books, 1964), pp. 21-62 for an elaboration.

⁸⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 177.

⁸⁹Ibid., p. 186.

⁹⁰Ibid., p. 187.

⁹¹L. A. Varma, "Rituals of Worship," The Cultural Heritage of India, p. 454.

⁹²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 179.

⁹³Ibid., p. 177.

as Vinoba applies his categorical imperative extending this individual good to all members of the society. Seeing how many people are entrapped by tamas due to their exploitation of the labor of others, Vinoba argues that it is in the spiritual interest of the rich to work with their own hands. He asserts that

All inequality, all ideas of high and low, slavery and violence have originated chiefly from the economic sin of avoiding bodily labor.⁹⁴

Thus, as one identifies oneself with the body, so also one may extend that identification to building up a corporation or a large plantation which one considers "necessary" in order not to work. Such economic walls also are in conflict with Vinoba's desire to establish a "welfare of all" consciousness.⁹⁵

If one has not, in addition, overcome rajas, one will be subject to emotional judgment generally, and personal ego fulfillment in particular. Where the identification with an illusory individual ego is not strong, there will be "unsteadiness" of purpose, according to Vinoba.⁹⁶ Where the ego is strong, one is predicted to either over-extend oneself in one's activities, so as to do little well (a violation of dharma) or, in the very least, one will perpetuate one's bhavana of "separateness" which is, of course, a spiritual barrier.

⁹⁴Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 28.

⁹⁵As an alternative to "private ownership" therefore, Vinoba advocates either collective ownership by the community, or a spirit of absolute trusteeship in the rich, which come to the same thing in his formulation.

⁹⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 187.

To live "within the limits of svadharma"⁹⁷ is the major step to take in the effort to destroy the rajasic element. One must, accordingly, confine one's actions and service to one's most immediate surroundings first.⁹⁸ After one's parents and neighbors are well taken care of, svadharma's sphere is allowed to legitimately grow. Such a focus on the "nearest" is considered to be good combat against the ego's belief in its own capacity to "change the world." Humility is fostered.

There is, in addition, the crucial importance of the results of one's actions for both the tamas and rajas-dominated individuals.

Says Vinoba:

The attitude that if I perform any act, I must also enjoy its fruit, illustrates the dominance of the Rajasic-element. On the other hand, the attitude that if I have to give up the fruit, I shall refrain from all action itself, betrays a Tamas-dominated nature.⁹⁹

The basis for such attachment to the fruits of one's actions is egoism—the sense of one's separateness from others. Thus, egoism must be conquered first before one can seek freedom from attachment.

"Egoism is conquered by constancy in sattva."¹⁰⁰ The intellect, or reason, the faculty which allows us to accumulate knowledge, unlike rajas and tamas "should be wounded, but not killed"¹⁰¹ since it is conceived as the way by which we may discover how similar

⁹⁷Ibid.

⁹⁸This is called the principle of Swadeshi in the political realm.

⁹⁹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 13.

¹⁰⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 190.

¹⁰¹Ibid., p. 187.

we are to other beings and how little, as individuals, we can do in this world. Also involved in this "constancy in sattva" is the removing of our identification with our mind which is, for Vinoba, to transcend our attachment to it.¹⁰²

One way to achieve victory over sattva, and hence, over egoism, is to so live that "sattva becomes so much our nature that we would cease to be proud of it."¹⁰³ In saying this Vinoba nevertheless agrees that the ways to God-realization of jnana and raja yoga, through knowledge and psychological exercises respectively,¹⁰⁴ are paths suited for only a few temperaments. For the masses of humanity, however, he agrees with most Hindus, sattva may be overcome only as "attachment is conquered by giving up the desire for results, and dedicating all to the Lord."¹⁰⁵ Thus, Vinoba admits, "our reliance is solely on Him to Whom we have dedicated our life. This is the path of devotion or Bhakti."¹⁰⁶

While Vinoba holds that individual swaraj can be achieved by "straight and simple bhakti"¹⁰⁷ the key to understanding the political

¹⁰²Ibid., p. 188. (One's mind, in other words, must be transcended.)

¹⁰³Ibid., p. 189.

¹⁰⁴See Huston Smith, The Religions of Man (New York: Harper & Row, 1965), pp. 36-39 and 51-52 especially, respectively.

¹⁰⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 190.

¹⁰⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 107.

¹⁰⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 102.

relevance of this is to realize that the object of the loving devotion is not some historical incarnation or other abstract principle or entity, but mankind today. Vinoba's bhavana of bhakti teaches that "one should look upon all men and women as so many images of God."¹⁰⁸ Since, for Vinoba, "Brahmin"¹⁰⁹ means any lofty exalted idea"¹¹⁰ pertaining to life, "Society" becomes, for him, worthy of the devotion of individuals.¹¹¹

Directing one's loving devotion, or bhakti, to Society, is, of course, consistent with Vinoba's Advaita Vedanta framework. Earlier it was noted how, according to this framework, there is no real conflict between individuals and society. Later it was discovered that the sense of attachment to the fruits of one's actions, and hence the gunas, could only be overcome "dedicating all to the Lord." Hence Vinoba combines the orthodox maxim that "renunciation of fruit is yoga, the art of living"¹¹² with his own objective of renunciation of private ownership to God, or Society,¹¹³ as a means of land redistribution.

According to Vinoba:

A psychological change like this cannot be brought about by war and violent revolution. It can only be

¹⁰⁸ Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 19.

¹⁰⁹ Brahmin is another name for the One, Undifferentiated, God or Atman.

¹¹⁰ Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 32.

¹¹¹ Ibid., p. 18.

¹¹² Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 19.

¹¹³ Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society, p. 62.

brought about by the methods of Buddha, Christ, Ramanuja and other great teachers. Ultimately, it is to be the dedication of one's all for the well being of all.¹¹⁴

The means of ahimsa, or nonviolence,¹¹⁵ is in this context, the only means compatible with bhakti yoga because "we reap what we sow, as is the desire so is the fruit."¹¹⁶ This Law of Karma, which is an important presupposition for Vinoba, recognizes that "it is possible to be non-violent in externals, and yet in fact be filled with violence"¹¹⁷ which, as a "quality of the mind"¹¹⁸ will impede the realization of the spiritual Oneness of all life. Thus, Vinoba responds to the question of "why should we love?" by simply saying that "from this the harmony of oneness is generated. This is Vedanta."¹¹⁹

Indeed, the means of love (agape—self-giving) and individual swaraj may be conceived of as inseparable components of the need which, if fostered by the mind's bhavana shall grow into the tree of moksha. Thus, "the individual 'ego' can be dedicated to God only after it has been merged in the collective 'ego'"¹²⁰ and this latter can be accomplished only through progressive identification with and loving

¹¹⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 19.

¹¹⁵Vinoba, Language Problem, p. 31.

¹¹⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 27.

¹¹⁷Ibid., p. 36.

¹¹⁸Ibid.

¹¹⁹Vinoba, Christ, the Love Incarnate, p. 34.

¹²⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 87.

devotion to all that lives. Even for the materially oppressed, therefore, "to resort to cruelty for freeing oneself from the blame of cowardly behavior is like flying from the frying pan into the fire."¹²¹

For the non-Vedantan, Vinoba argues that nonviolence, or love, is not only intrinsically good but is also practical from an instrumental perspective. Speaking broadly, for example, Vinoba observes that

. . . the Communists consider everyone among the rich as an enemy of the poor. This attitude (bhavana) makes the good as well as the bad¹²² among the rich join together with the result that the wicked among them gain more strength.¹²³

Class warfare, however, as "a process of revolution based on violence, is verily a process of reaction which can only result in counter-revolution"¹²⁴ for at least two reasons. First, it alienates potential allies within the opponent's class whose physical destruction, along with the others, is a loss of a well-educated and entrepreneurial resource who, as trustees, could be of great service to society.¹²⁵

¹²¹Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 48.

¹²²This should not be taken to mean that anyone can be totally "bad" or "wicked," for there is no devil theory in Sarvodaya. Rather, the terms are here used to denote the effects of one's actions. See Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 131, "we only look to the means he employs."

¹²³Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 16.

¹²⁴Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 28.

¹²⁵Generally, "trusteeship" is the alternative which both Gandhi and Vinoba advocate. Ultimately, for both, the "trustee" by his "trusteeship" surrenders all his wealth for the good of society.

Secondly, if we want a concern for human life to be increased, or, ideally, for even our opponent to improve in this regard, "we cannot do so by the use of physical force, which only heightens the body sense."¹²⁶ By threatening another's life, we destroy any consciousness he has of the common bonds existent, and remove the possibility of rational communication since the atmosphere is charged with fear.

Vinoba maintains that "what the world appears to us to be depends on the vision we have of it."¹²⁷ Hence, the bhavana (mental attitude) that another individual or class of people are "enemies" tends to make them appear to be enemies because that is what we draw out of them. Treated like enemies they usually act like enemies, thus re-affirming the bhavana.

What Vinoba advocates, in his bhavana of bhakti, is to refuse to act like an enemy even if an opponent considers one as such. This bhavana can make "the undeserving deserving and the evil good"¹²⁸ since, through non-retaliation, the conception of one as a threatening "enemy" is difficult to sustain. Moreover, it encourages communication and the seeking of Truth (which no one is, again, completely without) by refraining from a self-righteous or absolute judgment. Hence, Vinoba says:

¹²⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 163.

¹²⁷Ibid., p. 69.

¹²⁸Ibid., p. 109.

Who is to decide that a man (as such) is bad? Even if a really bad person appears before you, think that he is the Lord Himself. Even a villain will become a saint.¹²⁹

Vinoba's idealism, however, ought not to be labeled romantic primarily because he does not overlook the necessity of suffering. He tells us that "attachment to the body is not love. On the contrary, unless attachment to the body is put away, true love does not emerge."¹³⁰ True love, is, in fact, involved in loving one's enemy¹³¹ with a Christ-like readiness to lay down one's life rather than do harm to another. Observes Vinoba:

The body perishes every moment, understanding this, let him use it for the sake of svadharma. When there is need, let him not hesitate even to give it up for the sake of svadharma.¹³²

This may seem to contradict the earlier observation that, for Vinoba, the body is a prerequisite for attaining to God or Self-realization. However, in the context of his means-ends analysis, it should be clear that for him the means of Love (nonviolence or non-retaliation), is the seed which grows into the tree of Truth that is God realized in moksha. Thus, in swaraj the body is to be made to work and receive its noble service¹³³ but

¹²⁹Ibid.

¹³⁰Ibid., p. 15.

¹³¹Vinoba, Christ the Love Incarnate, p. 34.

¹³²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 17.

¹³³Ibid., p. 163.

Whenever there is a chance of the Supreme principle being defiled . . . I shall ever be ready to offer up the body in sacrifice in order to keep the flame of the Self brightly burning.¹³⁴

While, therefore, to attain perfect individual swaraj or self-realization requires one to be perfectly loving, Vinoba nevertheless holds that "there is nothing impossible for the soul"¹³⁵ and that "thought-force has no limitations."¹³⁶ The objective that "my ego should completely get destroyed"¹³⁷ is attainable if, at the point of death, one is so unattached to one's body as to dedicate all to the Lord, the Atman. To be so loving has, as an ideal, that of Jesus who is quoted by Vinoba as saying, "Thy will be done, Lord, forgive them for they know not what they do."¹³⁸

Like a Christian who believes "faith" and "works" to be inseparable, so also Vinoba tells us that "Bhakti yoga must be coupled with Karmayoga."¹³⁹ Bhakti, or loving devotion, is "the disposition to serve" while karma, or action, is the "actual service."¹⁴⁰ Accordingly, "the outer form of love is service"¹⁴¹ which is activity that is

¹³⁴Ibid., p. 167.

¹³⁵Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 37.

¹³⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 9.

¹³⁷Ibid., p. 14.

¹³⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 174. (see Luke 23:34)

¹³⁹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 123.

¹⁴⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 78.

¹⁴¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 204.

never renounced. Indeed, says Vinoba, "to renounce action is impossible for renunciation itself is an act."¹⁴² What is abandoned, ideally, is the sense of an ego either initiating action¹⁴³ or enjoying the fruits thereof.

Vinoba returns to the body/self dichotomy which is so central to his thought when he observes how

Some say: 'man is an animal who can make tools.'
I say: 'man is an animal who can use his body as a
tool for self-realization.'¹⁴⁴

It becomes such a tool not only as the bhavana of bhakti is developed within the individual's mind but also insofar as the bhakti is manifested in active service to others. Thus, we are told that "a devotee of God relishes karma yoga, the philosophy of action with non-attachment" because "that action to him is a form of worship."¹⁴⁵

Such action which has "an opportunity to serve the people," moreover, helps one to learn "to see 'God in every living being.'"¹⁴⁶ Thus, in this context of the necessity for karma yoga, we are better able to see why there are "unchanging duties" also included in one's svadharma. To fail to serve others, beginning with those nearest to one, would be an invitation to the rajasic element to become more dominant. To be willing to do others harm and, supposedly, serve

¹⁴²Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 27.

¹⁴³Ibid., p. 29.

¹⁴⁴Ibid., p. 31.

¹⁴⁵Ibid., p. 50.

¹⁴⁶Ibid., p. 17.

them at the same time would not only violate the means-ends relationship but also, if taken to an extreme (as the categorical imperative would demand), would destroy the very "other" who is a prerequisite for God-realization.

The individual seeker after swaraj, therefore, is dependent upon the existence of others to be of service to. All persons within a society, then, are viewed as individuals who are "interdependent"¹⁴⁷ upon the same God within each, so to speak. It is in this context that Vinoba observes that "we are, from the beginning, debtors" and how "discharge of the debt is yajna or service, not altruism."¹⁴⁸ Indeed "we have to beware of altruism"¹⁴⁹ not only because it fosters identification with one's ego but also because it tends to deny that "as we are born, our svadharma is also born with us."¹⁵⁰ The karma yogin, therefore, in addition to performing service for its own sake as a means of "spiritual development"¹⁵¹ also acts out of a sense of duty to the society he is so indebted to.

The general formulation of "the Lord to serve, I the servant, and creation the means"¹⁵² becomes, for Vinoba, less personal as the ego is subordinated to "the Lord." Ideally, the individual karma yogin

¹⁴⁷Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 202.

¹⁴⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 222. (underline mine)

¹⁴⁹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 12.

¹⁵⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 12.

¹⁵¹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 38.

¹⁵²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 201.

so transcends individual selfishness as to adhere merely to the maxim of "service to an individual and devotion to the whole society." ¹⁵³

Individual swaraj is thus attained to as one sees that "in truth, svārtha should be paramārtha, one's own good should be the supreme good" ¹⁵⁴ and one identifies "with the community" around one. ¹⁵⁵

At this point some of the complexity of the relationship between the swaraj (self rule) of individuals and collective swaraj may be appreciated. While true collective swaraj, as alluded to in my introduction, is literally the Sarvodaya ideal of Ram Raj (or the Kingdom of God) ¹⁵⁶ it would be unfair to conceive of its approximation as merely the sum of swaraj individuals have attained to. Just as the individual in society is dependent upon others for the fruitful practice of karma yoga in a spirit of bhakti, so also are those others dependent upon the renunciate's actions for material necessities of the body.

As discussed earlier, the bhavana of "I am the body" is recognized, by Vinoba, to be more likely as the body's needs are not met. The actions of the karma yogin, for Vinoba, become truly of service only insofar as they are conducive to the Self of others being realized by them. Accordingly the activity of Vinoba's seeker after Truth is dedicated to providing the material necessities of life to others beginning with those who are in most need. A dialectic of sorts

¹⁵³Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 18.

¹⁵⁴Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231.

¹⁵⁵Ibid., p. 31.

¹⁵⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 70.

is thus established with both the served and the serving benefiting spiritually.

At times, moreover, Vinoba's plea for individuals to take the responsibility of service upon themselves seems to take on an air of emergency. For example, he observes that

Unless the existing social order, which is based upon inequality, strife and conflict, is replaced by one founded on equality and mutual cooperation, there can be no salvation for mankind. 157

Quite probably Vinoba's urgency is a reflection of his concern about the potential effects of a nuclear war in today's world.¹⁵⁸ Since the "salvation of mankind" or the collective attainment of Ram Rajya has as a prerequisite the "survival of mankind" it would be no small wonder if Vinoba were disturbed about mushrooms on the horizon.

Be this as it may, Vinoba does admit that, unlike his youthful days, he has now a greater concern for collective swaraj.¹⁵⁹ This has prompted him, like Gandhi, to conduct expanded experiments of collective action as represented in the Bhoodan and Gramdan movements. Observing how "wherever you turn, you see nothing but walls,"¹⁶⁰ he has sought to break down these walls by hammering at their common root: man's bhavana that "I am the body."

¹⁵⁷Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 19.

¹⁵⁸Vinoba clearly believes that the "path of violence" has reached a dead-end from which mankind must change its course or be destroyed in the collision. See: Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 144-148, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 64, need for a "nonviolent army" Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 24, etc.

¹⁵⁹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 316.

¹⁶⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 13.

By organizing individuals and promulgating the ideal of karma yoga on a mass scale Vinoba hopes to create what he calls swatantra loka¹⁶¹ shakti, or "the self-reliant power of the people."¹⁶² This "power of the people" when manifested in different levels of society gives use to another useage of "swaraj." Thus, as Vinoba uses the term, "National swaraj" was attained when independence was won from the British but "Gram swaraj" or Village self-rule has not yet been attained.¹⁶³ Progressively, as the individual participates in the movements for national independence, then for regional autonomy and then for village self-reliance, Vinoba believes he or she will be brought to understand the ultimate spiritual importance of individual swaraj, and, simultaneously, Ram Rajya will be approached.¹⁶⁴

The means to be employed in this enterprise, as might be imagined, are of crucial importance to Vinoba. Karma yoga which is, by definition, the "way to God through right action"¹⁶⁵ is only effective if the "right action" is "right"—that is, as the bhavana of bhakti is manifested in it. Thus, the "power of the people" is, for Vinoba, a power which is "opposed to violence"¹⁶⁶ or even asserting "pressure

¹⁶¹Sometimes "jana" is substituted for "loka" and translated the same way. So, for simplicity's sake, I'll use "loka" here and, consistently, throughout the rest of the paper.

¹⁶²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

¹⁶³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 41.

¹⁶⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

¹⁶⁵Huston Smith, The Religions of Man, p. 45.

¹⁶⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

by the threat of violence."¹⁶⁷ It is based upon "the strength of good public opinion"¹⁶⁸ which, when exerted, always respects the life and integrity of the opponent.¹⁶⁹

When it comes, however, to comparing the swatantra loka shakti with the power of the State which has as its base "the coercive power of law"¹⁷⁰ Vinoba asserts that "though there is no direct opposition," still "the two are qualitatively different."¹⁷¹ For him

This insistance on rules (and law) arises from the fact that people are ignorant of the power of the soul. I do not know if there is anything more degrading than this ignorance of one's intrinsic power, the power of the soul.¹⁷²

To understand more fully why dependence upon law is undesirable, according to Vinoba, one must see the issue in the light of his general dislike for authority in any external coercive sense. This dislike, as analyzed in the next section, also provides a background to Vinoba's opposition to representative democracy.

¹⁶⁷Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 19.

¹⁶⁸Ibid.

¹⁶⁹Significantly, to the student of Gandhi, Vinoba seems much less willing to use any kind of coercion (in the sense of making another do that which is against his or her will) than Gandhi. Vinoba tends to equate violence with coercion. See Tikekor, Integral Revolution, pp. 12-13, 221 plus.

¹⁷⁰Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 104.

¹⁷¹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 97.

¹⁷²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 36.

II. ON DEMOCRACY

While the Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement was not written by Vinoba Bhawe, the imprint of his thought may be perceived throughout. Nowhere, however, is it more pronounced than in the statement that:

The Sarvodaya movement believes in the supreme importance of the individual. The ultimate goal of all evolution is the full flowering of his . . . creative autonomy. It is only self-knowledge that makes the uniqueness and autonomy not a threat to the world but its most cherished asset.¹

The individual is "supremely important" because the spiritual search for Truth, for Parama Sanya which is the "ultimate reality" of God,² can, for Vinoba, only be conducted by individuals. As was brought out in the previous section, "collective swaraj," while capable of being approached in an organized fashion, is based upon the actions of individuals practicing karma yoga in a bhavana of bhakti. The "self-knowledge" thus attained involves the "full flowering" of one's "creative autonomy" into a realization of the Vedantic unity of all life. For the mass of individuals in a society to realize the illusoriness of their "separate" interests requires, within Vinoba's framework,

¹ The Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement (Nagpur: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973), p. 22.

² Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 125.

that separate individuals come to progressively perceive the "good of all."

The vision of the common "good of all" is, moreover, impeded insofar as one is taught, or acquires, the bad bhavana of "I am the body." This attitude, however, is not confined to merely one's physical body but is extended, in Vinoba's thought, to include any attachment whatsoever. It is thus that Vinoba explains how "one man puts up an enclosure called 'attachment to family' and lives in it" while "another builds and lives in an enclosure called 'attachment to nation,'"³ Attachment to one's particular family, in this context erects a spiritual barrier to realizing the family of man while attachment to nation similarly impedes the essential idea that we are all citizens of the world. Indeed, for Vinoba, every object—including "government"—has two forms: an outer body (which breeds attachment) and an inner soul (worthy of devotion).⁴

Though he never goes so far as to expressly draw a distinction between "State" and "government," I believe a conception of the "State" as the "outer body" of "government" is implicit in Vinoba's writings. This would explain why he frequently uses the terms interchangeably⁵ while, at other times, he appears to more sharply

³Vinoba Bhave, Talks on the Gita (Varansi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 13.

⁴Ibid., p. 161.

⁵See, for example, Vinoba Bhave, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959), p. 80 etc.

separate the two concepts. For example, on the one hand "government" is somewhat countenanced, particularly if it is based upon widespread citizen participation,⁶ but on the other hand the "State" is consistently denounced as destructive of "individual initiative."⁷

In this context Vinoba's observation that "Sarvodaya" stands for "freedom from government, it means decentralization of power"⁸ becomes significant. Vinoba distinguishes the "freedom from government" objective from a "no government" ideal⁹ insofar as in the former "government" functions as modeled "upon the divine government-unseen, unfelt, and decentralized."¹⁰ Thus, insofar as "government" is decentralized it represents the divine ideal—the ideal of Ram Rajya,¹¹ the Kingdom of God, becoming into concrete existence.

It now appears that what has been called the "anarchism" of

⁶Numerous examples of this point will be cited later, in connection with Vinoba's conception of democracy.

⁷Vinoba Bhave, Gramdān for Gramswaraj (Vananasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 49.

⁸Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 3.

⁹Vinoba Bhave distinguished the two, as quoted by Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 48.

¹⁰Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 17.

¹¹Vinoba Bhave, "Ram Rajya . . . is what I call Sarvodaya," quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Kashi: Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 70.

Vinoba Bhave¹² might be better described as "anti-statism,"¹³ or a dislike of all government to the extent to which it is centralized. That the "State," or the "body aspect" of "government" which is reflected in the principle of centralization, is present in all existing governments is, in addition, recognized by Vinoba. He tells us that

We do not believe in the very institution of Centralized Government . . . this is a fundamental point of principle. And on this point, my opposition is there with all governments in the world, not excluding my own.¹⁴

The primary ground upon which Vinoba's extreme opposition to the State is based is, essentially, spiritual. As the bhavana of "I am the body" impedes the achieving of the "I am the Self" attitude, so also does the bhavana of "statism" prevent the individual from realizing that swaraj or self-government "means ruling your own self."¹⁵ This is not to say that the State may not provide its citizens with valuable material benefits since he admits that "political power can be an instrument of service."¹⁶ It is, however, to say that "the good work which is done by government services is very far from good in its effect upon the minds of the people."¹⁷

¹²See Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), pp. 32-44.

¹³See Mulford Q. Sibley, Political Ideas and Ideologies: A History of Political Thought (New York: Harper & Row Publishers, 1970), pp. 548-551.

¹⁴Vinoba, quoted by Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches, p. 69.

¹⁵Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 13.

¹⁶Vinoba Bhave, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 87.

¹⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 12

There is, we may recall, a spiritual requirement for every karma yogin, as a karma yogin, to adopt the active responsibility to serve society. In this context, one danger which State services poses is that, perhaps unwittingly, an attitude of "others will do the work of service" will be fostered instead of developing the habit of asking "Of what use could I be?"¹⁸ According to Vinoba the former attitude is the one which, on the whole, is in fact fostered, thus erecting a spiritual barrier against realizing the "oneness" of all life. While this is, of course, a subjective judgment upon his part, it would seem that it is certainly not an irrational conclusion.

Another danger, consistent with Vinoba's framework, is that the State might actually provide all of the services necessary for its citizens. In the last section it was shown how, ever prior to one's becoming a karma yogin, performance of bodily labor was seen as necessary for overcoming the tamasic element in one's nature. Of course, it is conceivable that the State could provide ample opportunity for physical work if that were considered a "need" of the citizen. Vinoba would seem to consider such a policy as unlikely especially since an attitude of general laziness would have been prompted in other areas.

If, however, a program of mandatory labor were to be enforced by the State, either physically or through subtle indoctrination, Vinoba would still oppose it. This opposition would be best understood by a thorough examination of Vinoba's statement that

¹⁸Vinoba Bhawe, Random Reflections (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1971), p. 108.

It is one mark of swaraj not to allow any outside power in the world to exercise control over oneself. And the second mark of swaraj is not to exercise power over any other . . . no submission and no exploitation.¹⁹

To allow oneself to be ruled by external forces means, for Vinoba, that one is not "ruling oneself" which is the essence of individual swaraj.²⁰ To have attained to this swaraj is, moreover, to have voluntarily surrendered oneself to the rule of "niti," the moral law,²¹ which consists of one's performing one's svadharma. Because, by presumption, the individual as a karma yogin must seek self-realization on his or her own, for the State, or even tradition, to enforce a particular dharma upon one must be resisted. Man is changing, as was noted in section one—changing so much as to require one's dharma (or occupation) to also change without limit. "Where there is a raj, a coercive government, niti is destroyed"²² because limitations are thereby placed upon the internal rule of the "moral law."

On the other hand, to exercise power over others, in the sense of exploiting them for one's own ends, destroys individual swaraj as the ego is given new life by such activity. It would, according to Vinoba's framework, not only increase the rajasic element in one's nature but would, in addition, violate the categorical imperative by not doing "unto others as you would have them do unto you." In both

¹⁹ Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 13-14.

²⁰ Ibid., p. 13.

²¹ Ibid., p. 15.

²² Ibid.

cases the realization of the spiritual end would be impeded by the Law of Karma which decrees that what is sown shall be reaped. Thus, for Vinoba, "He is a real lover of freedom, who feels that he himself also must not rule over others."²³

It is only, therefore, to the extent to which individual swaraj is both allowed and fought for (using non-violent means, of course) that the ideal of Ram Rajya is approached. This means, within Vinoba's religious-conceptual framework, that "The standard of life should be distinguished from the standard of living" and that "it is the former that is fundamental, not the latter."²⁴ While the "Welfare State," for example, may serve to increase the standard of living²⁵ it fails, according to Vinoba, to increase the "standard of life" which is not so dependent upon material satisfactions. The Welfare State, accordingly, like any other State, "becomes an ill-fare State"²⁶ by impeding the spiritual development of man.

To the extent, therefore, that power comes to be concentrated in the hands of the State, even a Welfare State,²⁷ acting in the service of its citizens, reduces the rule of niti and places spiritual barriers along the path of individual swaraj. Since all centralization of power in

²³Vinoba Bhawe, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 54.

²⁴K. G. Mashruwala, Towards Sarvodaya Order (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1971), pp. 99-100.

²⁵Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 41.

²⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 290.

²⁷Ibid.

government is thus, quite logically,²⁸ considered to be to the spiritual detriment of man, how much greater is the detriment, argues Vinoba, when the State can make the masses believe it "represents" them!²⁹ Thus, for Vinoba, the conclusion is implicit that representative democracy stifles the development of man as a spiritual being.³⁰ Indeed, he argues:

The truth is that no real freedom exists today, and we shall not get it so long as we carry on with our 'representative democracy' and do not take the management of our village affairs into our own hands.³¹

While the "State," in Vinoba's thought, may be conceived of as "government" to the extent to which power is centralized, "representative democracy" correspondingly connotes a condemnable form of "democracy." In that form, complains Vinoba, the mass of citizens take it "as a matter of course that anything to be done is the responsibility of the elected representatives."³² They become "sheep"³³ who, allowing the State to perform much of their svadharma for them, become spiritually impoverished even as they may be materially

²⁸ Logically—within the framework of Vinoba's religious thought.

²⁹ Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 71.

³⁰ This is my deduction, first mentioned in the introduction to this paper.

³¹ Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 64-65.

³² Vinoba Bhawe, Election and Democracy (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 23.

³³ Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 12.

benefited.³⁴ He would, in this context, agree that

The fundamental problem is the powerlessness and fatalism of the people . . . their lack of faith in themselves and the future they are capable of building.³⁵

The swatantra loka shakti, or "self-reliant power of the people,"³⁶ can only be generated, according to Vinoba, as a new bhavana is adopted which maintains that "In a democracy the people are everything and the government nothing."³⁷ The attitude that "the State has power over me" must be abandoned as power passes "into the hands of the people"³⁸ in more than a rhetorical sense. Vinoba claims that representative democracy is "only a formal democracy"³⁹ because people really only exercise power at election time, thus leaving the representative-elite free to rule, in interim periods, as they please.⁴⁰ For the masses to experience a liberation from their sheepish attitudes, Vinoba concludes, they must actively participate, as karma yogins, in both the formulation and execution of policies.⁴¹

It is in this context that Vinoba observes how "The essence of

³⁴Vinoba, giving Britain and the U.S. as examples, Election and Democracy, p. 18.

³⁵The Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement, p. 63.

³⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

³⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 20.

³⁸Vinoba, quoted by Tikekor, Integral Revolution, p. 102.

³⁹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 20.

⁴⁰Vinoba Bhawe, quoted by Adi H. Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (London: Asia Publishing House, 1967), p. 19.

⁴¹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 312.

democracy lies in the control of people over the Government."⁴² To the extent, in fact, the people as individuals "control" the Government that "government" becomes decentralized and the State's power is reduced. This process of decentralization, which is viewed as approaching the ideal of Ram Rajya, involves a progressive emphasis upon small scale units, like villages,⁴³ as the main units of government. Larger units, like regional federations,⁴⁴ would, in Vinoba's scheme, be countenanced as helpful for purposes of coordination of non-violent defense and utilization of resources, but would also be without recognized power to enforce their decisions.⁴⁵ Thus the mass of people would be given freer reign to participate in all matters which affect their lives and spiritual growth would be enhanced in the process.

It should be emphasized that Vinoba's conviction in the primacy of the small village units confines his notion of a justifiable polity to an extremely decentralized level. The concept of "nation," for example, is rendered as unnecessary as the perceived necessity for delegating authority in a large, centralized unit. Vinoba is, in fact, repudiating the developmental course of many areas which consider

⁴²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 9.

⁴³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 30.

⁴⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 106.

⁴⁵Such bodies, according to Vinoba, would rule by moral pre-eminence, by formulating policies which would so represent the consensus already arrived at as to not require any coercion to enforce them. Conflicts, should they arise before such an ideal is attained to, would be handled by "Satyagraha,"—or non-violent resistance in the Gandhian tradition. (See Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 61.)

"progress" mainly in material terms. In his village society ideal the spiritual "progress" of people to moksha (true freedom) is of the foremost importance and, decentralized as the structure is, delegation of authority through such means as elections is considered quite unnecessary.

Vinoba, furthermore, opposes the "election demon"⁴⁶ because the formal right to vote is, in his view, "like the right of the sheep to elect a shephard."⁴⁷ Instead of encouraging the masses to individual performance of svadharma, it promotes a bhavana of having done one's duty at the ballot box. As it discourages continued participation in the political process it increases the centralization of power in the hands of a few. Indeed it is not difficult, at this point, to perceive how Vinoba concludes that:

The whole arrangement, in fact, is sheer bogas It does even more harm than our former kings could do because our governments can now claim to 'represent public opinion.'⁴⁸

In addition to objecting to the veil of legitimacy constructed by virtue of elections, Vinoba has a fundamental dislike for the principle of majority rule. He recognizes that majority rule reflects the diction of "the greatest good for the greatest number"⁴⁹—a dictum which inherently denies the Sarvodaya view of "the common good of

⁴⁶ Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 84.

⁴⁷ Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 28.

⁴⁸ Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 71.

⁴⁹ Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 98.

all." It constitutes, in practice, "a new type of caste-difference"⁵⁰ which, while perhaps more fluid than the static caste tradition, nevertheless presents barriers which need to be overcome. Indeed, it promotes a bhavana in which individual conflicts of interest are treated as real and fundamental—quite contrary to the Sarvodaya teaching.

The majority rule principle also violates the means-ends relationship of Vinoba which decries coercing another to act contrary to his or her will.⁵¹ Vinoba asks:

Is not the rule of majority only brute force? How can you differentiate between the rule of the regiment, rule of money and rule of the majority?⁵²

His answer is, implicitly, that "brute force is brute force" wherever its rationale may be and, as such, represents "raj" (coercive state power). Since "raj," as has already been explained, is an impediment to the development of "niti" (moral rule), and hence of the "power of the people," majority rule is consistently denounced within the context of Vinoba's framework.

Furthermore, Vinoba asserts, "right and wrong cannot be decided by majority vote."⁵³ Only individuals, in his conception,

⁵⁰Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 21.

⁵¹Naturally, there are all sorts of problems in describing violence in this way. For example, one must know both what another's will is and what he or she would "otherwise do" before one can judge whether violent coercion is involved. Empirically, this is, at least at present, impossible.

⁵²Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 21. (brute force = backed by real or threatened physical sanction)

⁵³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. v. (A sentiment held by Dada Dharmadhikari and other Sarvodaya leaders too.)
www.vinoba.in

should decide right and wrong—although there is a place for opinion leaders who, by virtue of the respect they hold within a community, exercise a greater influence in decision-making.⁵⁴ Only when utilizing the principle of consensus, argues Vinoba, may this "greater influence" of some be reconciled with the duty of all to participate. Responsibility for deciding "right and wrong" is thus never really delegated in his consensus alternative.⁵⁵

Whether or not consensus democracy is a desirable or practical alternative to rule by majority is too complex a tangle to do justice to here.⁵⁶ What is important to note, for the purposes of this paper, is that, as borrowed from the Quakers,⁵⁷ consensus does not require unanimous agreement. In it a decision is deferred until there is no active opposition to it being implemented. Any majority, in other words, must take into account the minority perspective if any

⁵⁴Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 21. (Also, these "opinion leaders" will be dealt with in greater depth later, in a discussion of "capable leaders.")

⁵⁵Of course, a realistic application of this principle presupposes, Vinoba realizes, a decentralization of structure into small enough units that differing views might be openly expressed and compromises arrived at.

⁵⁶I encourage the reader to explore these questions, in the context of Indian society, by analyzing the arguments in support of Vinoba made by Sugata Dasgupta in A Great Society of Small Communities (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1968), pp. 50-51. Opposing arguments may be found, for example, in Doctor's Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (already cited), pp. 153-164. Concerning consensus decision-making in the Sarvodaya Movement itself one may turn to the Gentle Anarchists by Ostergaard and Currell, pp. 204-209.

⁵⁷Vishwanath Tandon, The Social and Political Philosophy of Sarvodaya After Gandhi (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965), p. 130.

decision is to be arrived at. From a practical standpoint all would be more likely to seek out the "common good of all" since it would even be in their perceived "self-interest" to do so. A spirit of cooperation, in consonance with the Sarvodaya ideal would, moreover, be much more emphasized than in any alternative scheme.⁵⁸

As it is, from Vinoba's empirical perspective,

Today, election and other works decided upon by the majority of opinion, in the name of democracy, have spread the poison of rivalry between parties and organizations in villages.⁵⁹

According to his experience "caste-differences have been fostered by elections in the country"⁶⁰ and other gulfs have been created because of parties seeking political power. He concludes that "It is entirely fictitious to believe that party-politics leads to the welfare of the people"⁶¹ because, among other reasons, parties indulge in "bargain driving" by their nature, while "The only kind of 'service' worthy of the name is disinterested service."⁶²

It should be made clear that it is not differences in views as such that Vinoba laments, but the establishment of parties seeking power on the bases of these.⁶³ Disservice is done as rivalries are

⁵⁸ Vinoba, quoted by Tandon, Sarvodaya After Gandhi, pp. 129-130.

⁵⁹ Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 278.

⁶⁰ Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 21.

⁶¹ Ibid., p. 23.

⁶² Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 46.

⁶³ Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study, p.

promoted thus enhancing the bhavana of "I am the body." In the Sarvodaya view "We will have to rise up above the petty considerations of caste, creed, language or province"⁶⁴ but political parties emphasize such distinctions for their own political advantage. This has harmful effects upon interpersonal relations too, since

If any spirit of bargaining, any tendency to invoke legal sanctions, enters into the mutual relationships of two citizens, it destroys the mutual trust and sense of fellowship between them.⁶⁵

"Bargaining" is further condemned even though Vinoba admits that differences in view are "necessary and inevitable."⁶⁶ Each individual's duty or dharma, is to do what he or she believes to be right according to the perception of Truth at any given point in time. Bargaining, in this context, is a violation of dharma, while a free exchange of relative perceptions of truth contributes to the individual's growth into a new dharma or higher consciousness of Truth.

From Vinoba's empirical standpoint, therefore, parties stand condemned on the grounds that loyalty to a party often overrides loyalty to the pursuit of Truth that is God.⁶⁷ Genuine criticism is stifled as the people become sheep to a shepherd's party⁶⁸ and honest criticism from opposition parties is frequently dismissed as

⁶⁴Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 45.

⁶⁵Dada Dharmadhikari, Introduction to Democratic Values, p. vii.

⁶⁶Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 27.

⁶⁷Ibid.

⁶⁸Ibid., p. 28.

partisan.⁶⁹ In this opinion framework, accordingly, Vinoba concludes that "to participate in the party system and in elections is to increase the stranglehold of party politics."⁷⁰

As might be imagined, however, Vinoba opposes political parties also, as political parties. The situation is similar to that of the principle of representation: "By casting our vote in favor of some party, we subordinate ourselves to power; we hardly do anything ourselves."⁷¹ A bad bhavana, in other words, is fostered in which individuals tend to surrender their svadharma to others. Vinoba's individual karma yoga base thus prompts him to remind us that "Lord Krishna enjoins upon us in the Gita that our deliverance has to be achieved by us only."⁷²

Sarvodaya, therefore, is not a party⁷³ and is "non-partisan in its approach."⁷⁴ As formulated by Vinoba, it is a theory which advises its adherants to "take part in political activities but not in political groupings" since they "must live like lions, not turn into sheep."⁷⁵ While some of his close associates have argued that one can,

⁶⁹Ibid., p. 27.

⁷⁰Ibid., p. 29.

⁷¹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 24.

⁷²Ibid.

⁷³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

⁷⁴Dasgupta, A Great Society of Small Communities, p. 11.

⁷⁵Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 69.

consistently, remain a "lion" even as a party member⁷⁶ Vinoba has remained steadfast in his position. To really understand the reason for this, we shall see, requires an analysis concerning his opinion that "power tends to corrupt."⁷⁷

While he admits that "there are some great souls who can keep their detachment even while holding a place of authority"⁷⁸ Vinoba holds that, in general, the temptations of office are such as to corrupt most people.⁷⁹ The tendency, Vinoba asserts, is for the office holder or the party leader to "become narrow in outlook"⁸⁰ as he or she becomes enamoured of the power position. This fosters the rajasic element in one's nature and, hence, one's ego, thereby serving to impede the destruction of the same. According to Vinoba

The problem lies at the very nature of authority⁸¹
 . . . (since) in general, the field of government⁸² is
 not a field of sacrifice. It does not afford natural
 opportunities for renunciation.⁸³

⁷⁶See Archarya Kripalani and Gora in Tandon's Sarvodaya After Gandhi, p. 172.

⁷⁷Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

⁷⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 53. (Probably, this is an allusion to Gandhi.)

⁷⁹Vinoba, as viewed by Noshir Bilpodiwala, The Social Order and Sarvodaya (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1963), p. 81.

⁸⁰Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, pp. 57-58.

⁸¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 138.

⁸²Here "government" should be understood as "centralized government" as is "representative democracy."

⁸³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 51.

The primary function of developing "the power of the people" is not, in this context, capturing political power so much as dispersing it. Such decentralization of government allows for more citizen participation and, thereby, the development of "the strength of the people." As the ideal of the karma yogin acting in a bhavana of bhakti (dedicating all fruits to God = Society), individual spiritual strength or swaraj is achieved. Correspondingly, the greater the detached service of individuals, freed of bargaining, the more is the collective swaraj made manifest. Thus, Vinoba tells us that

The politics of power is one thing while that of strength is another. People generally go after "power politics" but power cramps strength which increases with detached service.⁸⁴

Vinoba's prescription to "never accept political power"⁸⁵ follows, I believe, quite logically from his critical appraisals of the nature of coercive authority in general, of "representative democracy" in particular, and of the extreme tendency of power to corrupt the power-holder. However, just as one should not become enmeshed in attachment to one's body, family or State, for spiritual reasons, one must, nevertheless, participate actively in the society, as a karma yogin. The machinery of the State is destroyed,⁸⁶ therefore, as it is decentralized and

The greater the number of functions taken up by the

⁸⁴Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 17.

⁸⁵Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 8.

⁸⁶Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 226.

people from the government, the more non-violence will flourish and the more smooth will be the process of the withering away of the state authority.⁸⁷

Significantly, Vinoba agrees with Marx that the State, in any centralized administrative⁸⁸ or coercive sense,⁸⁹ will "wither away." This means, for Vinoba, that "there will be no State authority towards the end" and "the governance of the country will go on without the interference or function of any central power."⁹⁰ Such deminuation in the power of the State is, however, by no means inevitable—Ram Rajya is no certainty. For the "withering away" to progress requires a development of swatantra loka shakti giving rise to "lok niti" (moral rule by the people)⁹¹ and hence individual effort and purification. Thus, in Vinoba's view

It is only when a large group of people . . . aloof from positions of political power, but . . . endowed with the power of discretion and devoted in every way to service, sacrifice and study is formed on a permanent basis that the task of purifying . . . would be accomplished.⁹²

On the other hand, Vinoba maintains that until the "people's power" (or "strength of the people") is sufficiently developed, the

⁸⁷ Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 36.

⁸⁸ Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 19.

⁸⁹ "Society will reach such a stage . . . as would eliminate the necessity to run a government based on coercion or the power to punish."—Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 137.

⁹⁰ Vinoba Bhawe, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Pracharalaya, 1957), p. 19.

⁹¹ Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 15.

⁹² Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 2.

society needs a State and the State ought not to be directly attacked.⁹³ Indeed, "The right form of government depends upon the stage of development reached by the people."⁹⁴ Such a position, however, is not to say that the best form is not signified in the ideal of Ram Rajya. Vinoba, after all, continues to observe that we should not allow ourselves "to be governed at all, even by a good government."⁹⁵ It just goes to show that Vinoba realizes how

We have got to remember that although our present political system may not be a genuine government by the people, it is certainly government by the consent of the people. To change it we must change the people⁹⁶

While Vinoba never explicitly defines what is meant by "good government" as an intermediate stage between centralized government and freedom from government,⁹⁷ he does mention that in it the masses give their consent to be ruled by "capable individuals."⁹⁸ Considerable confusion and, I believe, genuine inconsistency is promoted by Vinoba at this point.

On the one hand, Vinoba sometimes implies that his "capable individuals" are the Sarvodaya movement's karma yogins who agree that "The politics of today . . . will change only when the people

⁹³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 209.

⁹⁴Ibid., p. 24.

⁹⁵Ibid., pp. 12-13.

⁹⁶Ibid., p. 57.

⁹⁷Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 65. (See also Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 25.)

⁹⁸Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 47.

change."⁹⁹ These workers would be "capable" by virtue of their own spiritual attainments and would, consistently, have authority only in proportion as the masses love them for their services. They would endeavor, through their actions, to teach by example the message they would have the masses embrace. This message of Sarvodaya would have all proclaim that

I live in the village and that village is an integral part of the world. God is our ruler and we, of the village, run our village-state by mutual consent and cooperative effort.¹⁰⁰

Such workers would promote individual swaraj even as they would avoid the corruptive temptation of wielding power over others. Renouncing all personal advantages these karma yogins would thus avoid all partisanship in their search for Truth. Indeed,

They (would) identify themselves neither with the government nor with the people. They should be independent of both, and render true service to both, by pointing out the virtues and faults of both sides, being friends of all but members of no party.¹⁰¹

On the other hand, Vinoba tells us that "to disclaim the authorship of all action is superior to capability,"¹⁰² thus strongly implying that his "capable individuals" are not the karma yogins of the movement. Instead of standing "in between the rulers and the ruled"¹⁰³ they would seem to stand as the rulers of the state whose objective

⁹⁹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 18.

¹⁰⁰Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 38.

¹⁰¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 207.

¹⁰²Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 7. (underline is mine)

¹⁰³Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 3.

may be "to see that every villager is his own ruler."¹⁰⁴ To say, in this context, that a "capable individual" becomes capable only "by mutual assistance"¹⁰⁵ and has "authority only to serve the people"¹⁰⁶ would appear to be but a feeble camouflage for an elitist rationale for change.

Such an impression is reinforced by Vinoba's observation that even if Government takes the form of "rule by one," still "if it is based on non-violence it should in reality be regarded as 'rule by all.'"¹⁰⁷ Since "There are only individuals who are more or less capable,"¹⁰⁸ (except perhaps, for a small though growing number of true karma yogins) the burden of raising the consciousness of the masses falls heavily upon those who are "capable" in any "good government" stage of development. Indeed, Vinoba tells us that

Those without education, without money, without land . . . cannot be expected to think about democracy. Hence this responsibility falls on . . . those who own land and wealth.¹⁰⁹

The initial picture of confusion, therefore, eventually yields to clear inconsistency. Particularly in Swaraj Sastra Vinoba reveals that by "capable individuals" is meant, not the karma yogins who have

¹⁰⁴Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 60.

¹⁰⁵Ibid., p. 55.

¹⁰⁶Ibid., p. 56.

¹⁰⁷Ibid., p. 27.

¹⁰⁸Ibid., p. 23.

¹⁰⁹Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 17.

renounced wealth and land, but the physically strong, the wealthy and the privileged.¹¹⁰ Such people, attached to their possessions and hardly expected to proceed forth in a bhavana of bhakti, are incapable of teaching swaraj to others. Indeed, within Vinoba's framework, they cannot even approach swaraj for themselves!

To say that "When we aim at freedom from government, we shall at least attain good government"¹¹¹ is no escape from the dilemma since, as has been pointed out, Vinoba believes the former to be an historical possibility. If the principle of representation must, as we have seen, be denounced as a means incapable of attaining to the ideal of Ram Rajya so also must a theory of "capable individuals" be dismissed. After all, the Law of Karma tells us that "we reap what we sow,"¹¹² centralization leads to centralization, and capable individuals give rise to others attached to the bhavana of "I am the body." To depend upon "capable" individuals would, in this analysis, be little different from dependence upon "capable" representatives.

Within Vinoba's framework even the occasional exception to the rule that power corrupts must be a karma yogin who believes in fostering individual swaraj in others. Such a person "will not use the government to change the people" but "will use the people to change the government."¹¹³ By his own analysis, however, Vinoba would seem

¹¹⁰Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 47.

¹¹¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 28.

¹¹²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 27.

¹¹³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 50.

to indicate that other individuals, not so detached, would (however "capable" they might be) almost invariably be corrupted by power. Such people would, in the least, predictably seek to have State policy force the masses to be free.¹¹⁴

To his credit, however, Vinoba does observe that "in a good State non-cooperation and resistance are occasional and depend on time and place."¹¹⁵ Indeed, sometimes he goes so far as to say that "Sin should be resisted wherever it appears"¹¹⁶ even, presumably, when manifested in a "capable individual." Such resistance, it might be surmised, could be led by those karma yogins of the Sarvodaya movement who, as superior to considerations of capability, would simultaneously teach the masses that

State-power and self-government are two different things. Power can be seized through violence. But self-government is impossible to be achieved without non-violence.¹¹⁷

Through non-violent resistance, or satyagraha, Vinoba hopes that it may be insured that the "good government" may "be so conducted as to leave the road open"¹¹⁸ to progressive decentralization.

¹¹⁴Again, here is a slip into a Rousseauian principle--quite contrary to Vinoba's anti-elitist framework.

¹¹⁵Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 65. (Note: There is, however, some confusion even on this point. See Tikekar, Integral Revolution, pp. 42, 132-133.)

¹¹⁶Vinoba Bhawe, Christ, The Love Incarnate (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1964), p. 34.

¹¹⁷Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 44.

¹¹⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 26.

Here, at least, Vinoba remains consistently opposed to any "dictatorship of the preletariat" conception during the intermediate, "good government" stage. He observes, accordingly, that "Decentralization of the power of the State should begin even now"¹¹⁹ arguing that "If the goodness in man is not relied upon, the State will never wither away at any time."¹²⁰ Means must be consistent with ends for the means are but the ends in embryo.

At this point it would be well to remember that the power of the State is exhibited in "the coercive power of law" (danda shakti).¹²¹ With regards to this power Vinoba has expressed an antipathy similar to his dislike for the State as such. He tells us, for example, that appropriation and redistribution of land by law fails, from a sarvodaya standpoint, to "unite the landholder's hearts" but rather "law tears them asunder."¹²² Because law is thus divisive and since, like the State's actions generally, it promotes a bhavana of separation and of being ruled, Vinoba concludes that "Legislation should not be forced on people."¹²³ It would appear, therefore, to be as logically an impure means of producing lok niti as centralization of power is for an end of decentralization.

At this point, however, there arises an inconsistency with

¹¹⁹Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 20.

¹²⁰Ibid., p. 19.

¹²¹Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 104.

¹²²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 36.

¹²³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 21.

regards to danda shakti to parallel that of his "capable individuals" doctrine. While, on the one hand, Vinoba proclaims that "We must realize that to accept government aide will weaken our vigour, understanding and strength,"¹²⁴ on the other hand he is so "anxious to provide a base to constructive work" as to allow it to "be supplied either by official legislation or by public approval."¹²⁵ He goes on to say that

Legislation may be of violent or non-violent nature and it may tilt towards either. If a legislative measure, even if it has the backing of the electorate, is not of a non-violent nature, that legislation itself will be violence.¹²⁶

I fail to see how any legislation, unless adopted by unanimous consent or unless devoid of punitive provisions, could qualify as being of a "non-violent" nature given Vinoba's framework. Such legislation, whether accomplished by a minority or a majority of the population would in either case be as much an example of "brute force" to those opposed as majority rule was argued by Vinoba to be for a minority. To say, moreover, that legislation is "non-violent" if it reflects or is supported by "the power of the people"¹²⁷ sounds like a Maoist claiming a Rousseauian right to utilize a "general will" to force people to be free.

That such an elitist approach is contrary to the sarvodaya ideal of individual karma yogins attaining to swaraj is obvious. As

¹²⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 53.

¹²⁵Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 30. (underlines are mine)

¹²⁶Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 31.

¹²⁷Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 31.

was discussed earlier, such swaraj excludes both being ruled by external forces and seeking to rule over others. The elitism of the devotee of God (in Society) consists in his/her obligation to perform svadharma, and lead, so to speak, by example. The bhavana of bhakti necessarily precludes, in Vinoba's framework, any resorting to questionable means in building the collective swaraj or swatantra loka shakti of the masses.

Vinoba does, however, qualify his sanction of the use of law by observing that

If a particular reform is voluntarily adopted by a number of individuals and if that voluntary action prepares the public mind for the change, then whatever little work is left to be done could be achieved through the process of law.¹²⁸

While non-coercive change is to be most relied upon, it is still evident that brute force is countenanced to finish "whatever little work is left to be done." Like Gandhi,¹²⁹ therefore, Vinoba believes that "the place for legislation . . . comes last."¹³⁰ This would seem to obviate any severe departure from principle as might occur if legislation were utilized as a primary means of bringing about change.

Vinoba's departures, in practice, from the ideal of non-violence, may be better understood by examining his statement that

¹²⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 39.

¹²⁹See Michael Johnson, "Gandhi and King on Jesus and the Use of Legislation as a Means of Producing Change," First Year Research Paper, 1973, esp. pp. 65-67.

¹³⁰Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 39.

The uses of the law are not for the morally good or for the morally bad, but for the morally weak.¹³¹

These "morally weak" persons are conscious that physical violence is undesirable and have thus evolved beyond the mentality of the "morally bad." Still, they have not attained the consciousness of "moral goodness" which, in the freedom from government stage of Ram Rajya, renounces all coercion. In short, the "morally weak" are those who, in the intermediate stages of "good government," need the State and insist upon using laws because they are "ignorant of the power of the soul."¹³²

Vinoba realizes that the kind of services done for the people by the State through laws is "not the kind of service which may be conducive to creating the conditions which will do away with the use of law."¹³³ As he indicated in his critique of the State and of representative democracy, to accept another's authority over one is to perpetuate that authority. Legislation and the actions of "capable individuals" might, it is true, lay a material foundation which, satisfying the needs of the body, may help the bhavana of "I am the body," to be overcome. True spiritual salvation, however, as we have repeatedly seen, can only be attained to by individual karma yogins seeking swaraj by performance of svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti.

While it is, therefore, "the character of the people and not

¹³¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 164.

¹³²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 36.

¹³³Ibid., p. 87.

the particular system in which they are bound together that guarantees justice"¹³⁴ that "character" is, nevertheless, a function of how decentralized the power of the State has become. The greater the decentralization, according to Vinoba, the greater the participation of the masses and, through participation, the more their swaraj grows. True democracy, in small units and without representatives, parties or voting, becomes, in this context, not merely a means, but also an end—"the end being the self-development of individuals."¹³⁵

In discussing democracy, therefore, Vinoba concludes by observing how "Today 'cracy' is strong while 'demos' is weak."¹³⁶ "Cracy," represented by institutions of representation (centralization) and such utilitarian instruments as elections and majority rule have become impediments in the fight to overcome the bhavana that "I am the body." Indeed, according to Vinoba, representative democracy "is committing suicide everywhere and the only remedy is to bring lok niti into being."¹³⁷ The suicide while spiritual in the sense that the people have become slaves, in their attitude, to the representatives,¹³⁸ is also political in the sense that an elite can, in the egoistic interest engendered by virtue of their power, exploit others for their own ends.

¹³⁴Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 61.

¹³⁵Ostergaard and Currell, The Gentle Anarchists, p. 205.

¹³⁶Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 11.

¹³⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 55.

¹³⁸"The situation is that the master himself has become a slave to the servant." Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 23.

Representative democracy is, in this analysis, held to be contrary to the development of man as a spiritual being. That Vinoba muddies the clarity of this position by inconsistently alluding to doctrines of "capable individuals" and of "non-violent laws" in the intermediate stages of "good government" does not detract from his main line of reasoning. Swatantra loka shakti develops as individuals acting and interacting in society come to realize progressively greater self-rule (swaraj). As the rule of niti (the moral law) evolves into existence through the efforts of karma yogins performing svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti, the ideal of Ram Rajya becomes more and more concrete in its being.

III. CONCLUSIONS

In 1972, when I had the brief opportunity to interview Vinoba Bhave at his ashram, I knew little of the intricacies of his thought. I had been informed, by friends, of his close association with Gandhi and about the key role he had played in the Bhoodan and Gramdan Movements. With a respect somewhat tinged with ignorance, therefore, I sat before the old man in the loincloth and wondered what I might intelligently ask. I resolved to confine myself to several questions I had formulated earlier, one of which was: "Do you agree with Gandhi that 'That government is best which governs least?'" He responded by saying:

No. The best government is that which governs not at all.¹

This reply, it should now be clear, cannot be fully understood except in the light of Vinoba's roots in the idealistic tradition of the Vedanta.² It is out of his "beloved Vedanta"³ that Vinoba draws the monism so clearly apparent in the "common good of all" approach

¹Vinoba Bhave, quoted by Michael Johnson, My Journal, January 8, 1972.

²"Vedanta connotes . . . final unitive glimpse of reality in which all possible conflicts of diversity are welded into one whole." Vinoba Bhave, quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Kashi: Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p.106.

³Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 81.

of Sarvodaya. From this assumption Vinoba logically concludes that the very idea of opposition is wrong and, hence, that even utilitarian perspectives of conflicts of interests between individuals or between the individual and society are illusory. Such perspectives, including the class notions of Marx, fail to realize that there is an unchanging and common good in all in moksha—the self-realization involving the recognition of the same Atman in all that lives.⁴

Perhaps the key term, in this context, is bhavana (attitude). As has been described, one must attain freedom from the bhavana of "I am the body" in order to transcend the gunas and one's sense of separateness. This spiritual swaraj takes on political connotations as Vinoba admits that, through socialization, one is taught the false bhavana and that this teaching process is perpetuated through dependence upon the State even as embodied in "representatives." It is the consensus of values in a society, therefore, which must be changed in order to promote the bhavana of "I am the Self" in the minds of everyone.

The status quo consensus is confronted obliquely by karma yogins performing their svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti. Refusing to allow others to do their duty of service for them these individuals devote themselves to serving God (in Society) eschewing power as a corrupting influence. In a sense, these sarvodaya workers constitute

⁴This may be termed the "mystical tinge" in Vinoba's thought. Atman = Truth = Parama Samya = Ultimate Reality. See Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), pp. 124-125.

the "iskra,"⁵ or sparks which may forge out a new order. Promoting their own swaraj by their activity they encourage others to live similarly, by their example. Like Vinoba they announce that "We aim at creating a kingdom of kindness"⁶ represented in the ideal of Ram Rajya where the growth of niti--the moral law--renders all appeals to coercion unnecessary.

Government, in the end, "governs not at all" for the people as a whole will have, individually, so attained to swaraj (or self rule) as to make the State "wither away." The Vedantic Sarvodaya truth that "All men belong to one human family"⁷ will be realized and "the paternal authority of God" will be recognized and respected.⁸ Progressive decentralization of the power of the State will have allowed a participatory democracy to give full vent to the potential of the karma yogin in every individual thus promoting a merger of individual swaraj into collective swaraj. In this way, Vinoba weaves a coherent theory in which

Society is freed from exploitation when relationships are no longer motivated by bargaining but by a sense of kinship. Society is freed from government when the spirit of human fellowship, rather than that

⁵"Iskra" is the term used by Lenin to describe the elite cadre, the "sparks" of the revolution.

⁶Vinoba Bhave, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 88.

⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 250.

⁸Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 54.

of constitutional and legal relationships, controls social life.⁹

In spite of his steadfast adherence to the Law of Karma, which thus precludes any doctrine that "the means justify the ends" Vinoba's approach may clearly be seen as a threat to the existing order. He admits, for example, that as a first step towards a spiritual revolution in society, the material needs of the poor must be met. But this is not all, for just as the problem of the landless cultivator is overcome the next step is engaged in which "there should be no land-owner."¹⁰ Vinoba honestly observes that "I am certainly out to create discontent"¹¹ for he is conscious that the status quo will not support him as it realizes that his ultimate economic goal of "From each according to his ability to each according to his need"¹² involves, as does his Marxian counterpart, an abolition of private property.¹³

Nevertheless, while the eminent Indian Communist leader E. M. S. Namboodiripad admits that Vinoba's approach is "as revolutionary as any socialist or communist would have"¹⁴ he holds

⁹Dada Dharmadhikari, in Introduction to Democratic Values, pp. vii-viii.

¹⁰Vinoba Bhave, quoted by Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 65.

¹¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 150.

¹²Vinoba Bhave, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959), p. 75.

¹³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 418, 173 etc.

¹⁴E. M. S. Namboodiripad, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 74.

that it has severe limitations. First, he holds with Adi H. Doctor the opinion that Sarvodaya "can have little attraction for the atheist"¹⁵ due to its emphasis on God. For all his use of orthodox terminology, however, Vinoba explicitly holds that "God manifests himself both in the Astika (theist) and in the nastika (Atheist)."¹⁶ Describing the "cardinal religion of man" as "Humaneness,"¹⁷ Vinoba emphasizes that

The only thing that is a must for a Sarvodaya worker is that he (or she) believe in the indivisible and harmonious character of human good and in the non-violent means to attain it.¹⁸

It must, however, be granted that to require a belief in a "common good" and in the Law of Karma would certainly limit the appeal of any movement today. The paucity of volunteers, even in India,¹⁹ however, cannot be a conclusive criterion with which to pass judgment upon the potential of the sarvodaya approach. After all, Vinoba hardly predicts that the masses of the people, taught for centuries that willingness to act violently is the only viable means of self-defense, will be converted wholesale to the alternative of non-retaliation.

Indeed, Namboodiripad and Doctor reflect the poor under-

¹⁵Adi H. Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (London: Asia Publishing House, 1967), p. 169.

¹⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 170.

¹⁷Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 34.

¹⁸Vinoba, paraphrased by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p.

147.

¹⁹See, for details, Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971). www.vinoba.in

standing, which most people cherish, in their second major criticism: "Self sacrifice is surely anti-biological."²⁰ While I have pursued a study of Satyagraha elsewhere²¹ it should be sufficient to observe that even a good soldier must be willing to die for the "self-preservation" of society. There is no guarantee of individual survival irregardless of the approach to action used, although, from a psychological viewpoint, many experts agree that a non-violent approach may even be preferable.²²

A crucial obstacle to the promotion of radical change by any means is fear. Vinoba's conceptualization of attaining swaraj through doing one's duty in an attitude of love successfully provides a context within which individuals may overcome fear. While, in the case of the deist this may involve adherence to a faith in a Day of Judgment or in reincarnation, the realization of "I am the Self" for the atheist may involve a this-worldly devotion to the community or to an ethical standard. In any case, Vinoba's doctrine of swaraj holds that "Those who fear death have ceased to live"²³ because they have ceased to grow in understanding—have ceased to act Undoubtedly, Vinoba would be pleased to hear G. D. H. Cole, the great scholar of Marx, say:

²⁰ Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 171.

²¹ Michael Johnson, Satyagraha: An Alternative, Whitman College Honor's Thesis, 1971.

²² See Jerome Frank, Eric Fromm, Eric Erickson and others, Ibid.

²³ Vinoba Bhave, quoted by George Weller, "Vinoba Bhave: India's Walking Messiah," Yale Review 42: No. 2: December 1952, p. 243.
www.vinoba.in

I agree that for us as well as for Indians, Swaraj must be an individual as well as a political experience. It must come to us as something that fills us with a power to deny fear.²⁴

Unlike many Marxists, particularly bolesheviks, Vinoba's approach directs the fearlessness of the individuals to the decentralizing of the State beginning now.²⁵ This utilization of the karma yogin iskra may appear as a conceptual contribution by anyone disillusioned with the progress of the "withering" away of the State in the Soviet Union or elsewhere. In spite of Vinoba's inconsistencies²⁶ the general line of this reasoning has led him, as we have seen, even to denounce theories of representative democracy.

At this point, perhaps, it may be admitted that Vinoba's ideal of the Kingdom of God becoming established on Earth may be a bit "utopian."²⁷ Vinoba, himself, seems to vacillate on this point as, on the one hand, he claims it is historically possible²⁸ while, on the other, he observes that "virtue lies in taking up only an impossible program."²⁹ But ought our vacillation be any less than Vinoba's? In pursuing dreams deemed "impossible" by many of their contemporaries man has shown himself capable of eradicating many diseases from the world, flying to

²⁴G. D. H. Cole, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 443.

²⁵See Ostergaard and Currell, The Gentle Anarchists, p. 41.

²⁶i. e., "capable individuals," "non-violent legislation," etc.

²⁷Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 165.

²⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 3.

²⁹Vinoba Bhawe, Gramdan for Gramswaraj (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 19.

the moon, and so developing weapons' technology as to be able to destroy the world more than fifty times over. Ought we to condemn the thought of man (even the community of man) of being incapable of evolving to new heights? Author Kingsley Martin, at least, would seem to answer in the negative as he writes that

The mere multiplication of advertised goods, the mere speeding up of communications, the greater efficiency of machinery will benefit no one unless, like Bhava, we learn to think of ourselves as a family sharing, rather than as animals in a jungle in which we prey on each other.³⁰

According to Vinoba "we have already become citizens of the world, science has perforce made us citizens of one world."³¹ Because of man's rapidly advancing technological capabilities, particularly in the realm of nuclear warfare, he concludes that "We are sitting on the edge of a volcano."³² If his analysis is correct—that the world has shrunk today into an interdependent community, and that this community is threatening itself with the practical possibility of annihilation—perhaps the idealism of Vinoba is realistically important. His approach, at least, provides a hope that "an age is what we make it to be"³³ while, at the same time providing an impetus to manifest the necessary changes beginning now. Indeed,

³⁰Kingsley Martin, "The Gandhi Way," Atlantic Monthly 206, August, 1960, p. 66.

³¹Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 3.

³²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 58.

³³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 86.

I say that both the past and the future are beyond our control. Only the present is in our hands and we must, therefore, endeavor to bring Sat-Yoga (the age of Truth) in the present.³⁴

Whether "the human family" is a pre-existent reality which needs to be comprehended or a myth which is an instrumental necessity for modern survival is a matter of faith. If, in either case, one agrees with Vinoba that it is an attitude which needs to be brought into the consciousness of the masses, the means to this end might well prove to be crucially important. Certainly, if the Law of Karma is true, "compassion, sharing and sacrifice," in short "nonviolence" will be an instrumental necessity.³⁵ Even if the "how" is not so clear, perhaps the individualist emphasis throughout Vinoba's philosophy will nevertheless seem as relevant as it was for Albert Einstein as he wrote:

The only conceivable way of bringing about a reconstruction of our world on new lines is first of all to become new people, ourselves, under the old circumstances.³⁶

³⁴Ibid., p. 200.

³⁵Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement (Nagpur: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973), p. 26.

³⁶Albert Einstein, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 474.

APPENDIX I

Below are listed all of the Indian terms and phrases which were used at least once during the course of this paper. All corresponding translations take Vinoba's meaning into account.

advaita vedanta	monastic unity of God (Shankara philosophy)
ahimsa	harmlessness, non-violence, love
antyodaya	uplift of the last one
archarya	teacher
ashram	Karma yogin center for action
astika	theist, one who concentrates on God as external
bhakti	devotion, love
bhakti yoga	the way to God through love
bhavana	attitude, mind-set
bhim	a spiritual Hercules
bhoodan	land-gift
Brahmin	any lofty, exalted idea (like Society) pertaining to life
danda shakti	the coercive power of law
dharma	changing duty (occupation)
gramdan	village-gift
gunas	the qualities of nature
jnana yoga	the way to God through Knowledge
Karma yoga	the way to God through action (work)

Karma (Law of)	Means/Ends = Seed/Tree
loka shakti	the power of the people
lok niti	the moral rule of the people
mahatma	great soul, saint
moksha	self-realization, salvation
nastika	atheist, one who concentrates on God as internal
niti	moral rule
paramartha	universal good
Parama Samya	Ultimate Reality, Truth
raj	coercive rule of the State
rajas	laziness
raja yoga	the way to God through mental exercises
Ram Rajya	the Kingdom of God; collective moksha
rishí	holy man
Sampati sab Raghupati Ki ahi:	All wealth belongs to God.
samya yoga	equal reverence for all life
Sarvodaya	the uplift of all, welfare of all, common good
sattva	reason, knowledge
Satya	Truth, God, Atman, Parama Samya
satyagraha	holding firm to truth, non-violent resistance
sat yoga	the age of Truth
shakti	power (usually coercive)
svadharma	duty (including both changing and unchanging)
svartha	personal (individual) good
swaraj	self-rule, self-government, freedom, salvation
swatantra loka shakti:	the self-reliant power of the people

tamas	egoistic activity
Tat tvam asi	You are the Self.
vedanta	philosophy of oneness, monism
yajna	sacrifice, suffering
Yatemañi Swarajya	we shall strive to attain this swaraj
yoga	Way of Life
yogin	one who has a way of life

APPENDIX II

Among the key terms in Vinoba's thought are: God, man, society, state and government. While much of this paper has dealt with the interrelationships among these terms, it is possible that the reader may have lost sight of the trees by virtue of the forest. For the purpose of clarifying these terms, therefore, I hope that the following descriptions may be helpful. Let the reader remember, however, that these are my impressions of what Vinoba means by each term:

God

God is the same Atman (Spirit, Soul, Self) which exists in microcosm in all the lives. God is Parama Samya, ultimate reality, and Truth. God is the life-force which informs all matter. God is Love, the self-sacrificing agape, which is the means to the realization of Truth which is itself. (Law of Karma.) God is One.

Man

Man is made up of the Self, the Body and his Mind. Man who has the unique capacity to reflect with his mind may identify himself either more with the Self or more with the body. Insofar as the bhavana (mental attitude) "I am the body" is adopted apparent conflicts of interests emerge between individuals and groups and the realization of the Self is impeded. Insofar as one has the bhavana of "I am the Self"

one has swaraj (self-rule) and is close to God. Complete swaraj, attained through karma yoga practiced with a bhavana of bhakti, is ultimately resultant in moksha (self-realization). True freedom consists in moksha. "Essential" man is God.

Society

Society is both the sum of the individuals composing it as well as a necessary prerequisite for each individual to attain to moksha. The ultimate good of society is the same as that of each of its individuals and is attained insofar as swaraj is reached on their parts. Ram rajya (the Kingdom of God) comes to earth as more individuals attain to moksha. As each karma yogin, however, requires other individuals to be of service to and cannot arbitrarily confine svadharma to any particular person or group, the sum of individuals (society) becomes necessary as a prerequisite for the moksha of any. Devotion is thus directed to the Atman in each individual (totalled = society = world).

Government

Government, while composed of individuals, may be thought to have, like each person, a spirit (essential aspect) and a body (peripheral aspect). The essential aspect is, literally, the ideal of literal self-government (swaraj) of each person over oneself (i.e., one's body). The divine government of Ram rajya is "freedom from government" where the moral law of "niti" so rules as to make it seem like no government exists. The peripheral aspect of government is the State.

State

The State is every government to the extent to which it is centralized. It is the "body aspect" of government which breeds conflict and spiritual barriers to the extent it is identified with. The bhavana of "statism" considers it legitimate to allow others to rule over oneself rather than for one to rule over oneself completely. The State, therefore, is diametrically opposed to swaraj and, hence, must be made to "wither away" for all to attain to moksha.

<u>soul</u>	=	<u>niti</u>	=	<u>decentralization</u>	=	<u>participation by all (ideal)</u>	=	<u>demos</u>
body		raj		centralization		participation by few or many		cracy

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